



The Key Teachings of
WATCHMAN NEE

*Except a corn of wheat fall into the
ground and die, it abideth alone: but
if it die, it bringeth forth much fruit.*

JOHN 12:24

OCHORUS

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Published by Ochorus.

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Introduction

Verily, verily, I say unto you, Except a corn of wheat fall into the ground and die, it abideth alone: but if it die, it bringeth forth much fruit.

JOHN 12:24

There is a kind of Christian teaching that adds information to the mind. There is another kind that quietly dismantles a man. The ministry of Watchman Nee belongs to the second kind, and that is why, more than fifty years after he died in a labour camp in Anhwei province, his words are still read in languages he never spoke, in countries he never visited, by believers who were not born when he was buried.

He was not a systematic theologian, and he would have been uneasy at being called one. He wrote no volume of dogmatics, founded no seminary, and left behind no confession of faith bearing his name. What he left behind was something both smaller and larger: a body of spoken ministry, taken down by listeners and afterwards gathered into books, which pressed a single question upon the conscience of the believer. The question was not *What ought I to do for God?* It was *What has God already done, and am I willing to stand upon it?*

That question runs like a seam of ore through everything he taught. It is there in *The Normal Christian Life*, where he laboured to show that Romans chapters six to eight are not a counsel of effort but a declaration of accomplished fact. It is there in *Sit, Walk, Stand*, where the Christian's whole conduct and warfare are made to rest upon a prior resting. It is there in *The Release of the Spirit*, where the great hindrance to fruitfulness is located not in the believer's weakness but in his unbroken strength. And it is there, most painfully, in the last twenty years of his life, when the man who had taught the church about the cross was himself required to bear one.

This book is an attempt to set out, in eighteen short chapters, the teaching for which Watchman Nee is chiefly remembered. It is written for the ordinary believer — the pastor with more congregations than books, the student who has heard the name and wants to know what the fuss is about, the professional who is respected at church and quietly defeated at home, the believer who has been trying for years to live the Christian life and has begun to suspect he is going about it the wrong way entirely.

A word about how to use it. Each chapter is deliberately short, and each one ends in the same two places: a set of application points, and a

prayer. This is not decoration. Nee held, with some force, that spiritual truth which is merely understood has not yet been received at all. He was fond of pointing out that revelation in Scripture is almost always followed immediately by demand. The Lord shows a man something, and then requires something of him. A chapter of this book that is read and admired but not obeyed has, by its own argument, failed. Read one chapter a day, or one a week. Stop at the application points. Pray the prayer, or better, pray your own.

A word also about the limits of this book. It is a summary, and every summary is a kind of flattening. Nee's actual ministry is richer, stranger and more uneven than any digest of it can be, and there is no substitute for going to the works themselves. Throughout these pages his own books and spoken addresses are named, so that the reader may follow any thread back to its source. A short guide to those works is provided at the end.

One more thing must be said at the outset, and it is better said plainly.

This is not a book of hero-worship. Watchman Nee was a man, and the record of his life contains matters that are painful, contested and, in some particulars, probably unknowable this side of eternity. There were seasons of controversy among his own co-workers. There was a period of some six years in which he withdrew from the Lord's Table. When the state finally tried him in 1956, the charges laid against him included moral and financial ones; his defenders have always insisted these were manufactured by a hostile government determined to destroy his credibility, while some careful historians have concluded that not all of them were. The trial was conducted under a regime that had every interest in his ruin, which makes the evidence extremely difficult to weigh at this distance.

The reader may be tempted to ask why a book of this kind would raise such a matter at all. The answer is that Nee himself would have insisted upon it. No teaching was more central to him than that the flesh — including the religious flesh, including the gifted and useful and admired flesh — is utterly untrustworthy and must go to the cross. A book that presented him as a spotless saint would be contradicting the very doctrine it was written to commend.

So the counsel of this book is the counsel of Scripture: *Prove all things; hold fast that which is good* (1 Thessalonians 5:21). Weigh every chapter against the Word of God. Where Nee is faithful to Scripture — and on the great themes of the cross, of union with Christ, of consecration and brokenness and the Body, he is very faithful indeed — receive it gladly and act upon it. Where he presses beyond what is written, and there are places where he does, mark it, set it aside, and lose nothing.

Truth is not damaged by being carried in an earthen vessel. That, after all, is the only kind of vessel God has ever used.

One final observation, which may explain why this particular ministry has travelled as far as it has.

Watchman Nee wrote in Chinese, for Chinese believers, in a country sliding into war. He never intended a worldwide readership and would very likely have been embarrassed by one. Yet his books have crossed nearly every border that exists, and are read today in languages he never heard spoken, by Christians whose circumstances have nothing in common with his own.

The reason is not literary. It is that he dealt almost exclusively with what does not vary. Cultures differ enormously in what they prize, permit and punish; the human heart is depressingly uniform. Self-reliance, the instinct to earn, the reluctance to be broken, the preference for governing oneself — these require no translation. A believer in a wealthy suburb and a believer in a village without electricity are further apart in circumstance than almost any two people in history, and they are wrestling with precisely the same man in the mirror.

So this book assumes no particular setting. Wherever it is read, and into whatever language it is carried, the questions it raises will already be waiting.

There is also this. Nee did not teach the deeper life from a position of comfort. He taught it to workers who would shortly be scattered, and he sealed it by returning to Shanghai in 1949 when he could have stayed away, and by refusing, through twenty years of imprisonment, to purchase his freedom by denying his Lord.

A man may teach the cross with his mouth. Nee was required to teach it with his life. That is why we still listen.

A Life Poured Out

I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith.

2 TIMOTHY 4:7

The child who was asked for. He was born on the fourth of November, 1903, in the coastal city of Swatow, in southern China, and given the name Ni Shu-tsu. His father, Ni Weng-hsiu, was an officer in the Imperial Customs Service; his grandfather, Ni Yu-cheng, had been among the earliest Chinese to be ordained as a Protestant preacher in Fukien province. The family was Christian, respectable and Methodist, and the boy was baptised as an infant by a Methodist bishop.

His mother, Lin Ho-ping — Peace Lin — had borne two daughters and desperately wanted a son. In the manner of Hannah at Shiloh she vowed that if God gave her a boy she would give him back. God gave her a boy. It would be nearly eighteen years before either of them understood what the vow had cost.

The child was brilliant. He read early, argued well, and swept the prizes at the mission school in Foochow where the family had returned to live. He was also, by his own later account, a thoroughly worldly young man — clever, ambitious, contemptuous of the religion of his parents, and privately determined to make a name in the world. Christianity he regarded as a sentimental encumbrance suited to women and the elderly.

April 1920. In the spring of 1920 a Chinese evangelist named Dora Yu came to Foochow to preach. Dora Yu had trained in medicine and abandoned it for the gospel; she was a Methodist, a woman of prayer, and she preached with a directness that cut. Peace Lin went to the meetings. What happened to her there was so thorough that she came home and did something no Chinese mother of that generation would ordinarily do: she apologised to her son for a wrong she had done him.

It undid him. He went to hear the preacher for himself. On the evening of the twenty-ninth of April, 1920, alone in his room, seventeen years old, he surrendered to Jesus Christ.

The change was immediate and total. He began at once to witness — to classmates, to teachers, to anyone within reach — and he drew up a list of some seventy friends whom he undertook to pray for, in some seasons every hour of the day. Before long he changed his name. Ni

Shu-tsu became Ni To-sheng: *the sound of the watchman's rattle*, the night-watch clapper struck in the darkness to rouse a sleeping town. In English he would be known for the rest of his life as Watchman Nee.

The teacher he needed. He went first to Shanghai to train under Dora Yu and was sent home again, having proved an undisciplined student. It was Dora Yu who then pointed him toward the woman who would shape him more than any other.

Margaret E. Barber was an Englishwoman in her fifties who had come out with the Church Missionary Society, returned to England under a cloud of accusation she refused to defend herself against, and come back to China as an independent missionary answerable to no board and supported by no salary. She lived simply at White Teeth Rock, near Pagoda Anchorage on the Min River, and she took the brilliant young convert in hand.

She was severe with him. She let him wait; she rebuked him; she declined to flatter a gift that everyone else was already praising. He would say afterwards that she taught him the cross by administering it. She also opened her bookshelves. Through Margaret Barber, Nee met the writers who would furnish his theology for life: the Brethren expositors — Darby, Mackintosh, Robert Govett, G. H. Pember, D. M. Panton; the Keswick and deeper-life authors — Andrew Murray, Jessie Penn-Lewis, Evan Roberts, F. B. Meyer; and the older mystics, above all Madame Guyon, whose little treatise on prayer he would translate into Chinese.

In 1921 he was baptised by immersion, having concluded that his infant baptism was no baptism at all. Margaret Barber died in 1930 and left him her few possessions.

Ministry, illness, and the little flock. From 1922 he and a handful of friends began breaking bread together in Foochow, outside the denominational structures, as simply *the church* in that place. Others joined. The movement that grew from those meetings would be known to outsiders as the Little Flock, and to its own members as the Christian Assembly, or more plainly the church in whatever city it happened to be. By the time of his arrest thirty years later there were some four hundred such assemblies across China, and others in Singapore, Malaysia, Indonesia, the Philippines and Thailand.

He began publishing almost at once. His periodicals — *The Present Testimony* and *The Christian* — carried his exposition to readers far beyond the reach of his voice.

Then his health broke. From the middle of the 1920s he was gravely ill with tuberculosis, for long stretches unable to walk across a room, repeatedly given up by his doctors. It was in this condition, expecting

to die, that he wrote his first major work. *The Spiritual Man*, three volumes on the threefold constitution of man, was published in 1928. He later said the labour of it had cost him more than it was worth, and cautioned readers against making a system out of what he had written — but the book established him.

In 1927 the work moved to Shanghai, which became its centre.

Abroad. He travelled to the West twice. In 1933 he visited England and met the Exclusive Brethren, whose literature had formed him and whose exclusivism afterwards led them to break with him. He also spent time at Honor Oak in south London with T. Austin-Sparks, who became a friend.

The second visit, in 1938 and 1939, was the more consequential. Speaking in England, Denmark and elsewhere in Europe on the eve of the war, he gave the series of addresses on Romans that were afterwards gathered, edited and published as *The Normal Christian Life*. It remains, by a wide margin, the book by which the English-speaking world knows him.

In 1934 he had married Charity Chang, whom he had known since childhood; the marriage drew criticism from some quarters and cost him friendships.

The wilderness years. In 1942 the work suffered a rupture. Nee had become involved in a pharmaceutical business, the China Biological and Chemical Laboratories, founded with his brother, intending its profits to support the workers. The elders of the Shanghai assembly judged this unbecoming in a servant of God and asked him to cease ministering. He submitted. For roughly six years he did not break bread with the church he had raised up, and did not preach.

Those years are variously interpreted. His defenders describe a humble submission to misguided brethren. Others, including some who knew him, believed his own conscience was involved. He himself said little.

In 1948 he was restored to fellowship, and there followed the most remarkable period of his teaching ministry: the trainings for workers held on Kuling Mountain, near Foochow, in 1948 and 1949. Out of those sessions came *Spiritual Authority*, *The Character of God's Workman*, and much else. He also called the believers to *hand over* — to place their homes, properties and livelihoods at the disposal of the Lord and the church. Many did.

The last chapter. The Communists took the mainland in 1949. Nee was in Hong Kong early in that year, safe, with every opportunity to remain. In February he decided to go back to Shanghai. He understood

what he was choosing.

For a time the churches continued; the Shanghai assembly still gathered thousands. Then the Three-Self Patriotic Movement was organised, and the pressure to submit the churches to state control became irresistible. Nee would not.

He was arrested on the tenth of April, 1952. For four years the believers did not know where he was. In January 1956 he was denounced at a mass accusation meeting in Shanghai, before a crowd that included his own former co-workers, and an indictment of some two thousand pages was published against him. Later that year he was sentenced to fifteen years' imprisonment.

He was never released. When the fifteen years expired in 1967 he was simply kept. It is said that freedom was offered him more than once if he would lead a state-approved church, and that he refused every time. Only his wife was permitted to visit. Charity died on the seventh of November, 1971; he was not allowed to attend her funeral.

Watchman Nee died on the thirtieth of May, 1972, at a labour farm in Guangde, in Anhwei province, sixty-eight years old, having spent twenty years in confinement. A grand-niece who came to collect his effects was given a scrap of paper found beneath his pillow, written in his own hand. Its substance was that Christ is the Son of God who died for the redemption of sinners and rose on the third day — and that he, Watchman Nee, died believing it.

The watchman had kept his post until the morning.

The Normal Christian Life

I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me.

GALATIANS 2:20

Watchman Nee opened his most famous book with a question that sounds almost impertinent. What, he asked, is the normal Christian life?

The word matters. He did not ask what the *ideal* Christian life is, or the *advanced* Christian life, or the life of those unusual saints whose biographies we read with admiration and no expectation of imitation. He asked what is normal. And he answered that the normal Christian life is the life described in Galatians 2:20 — a life no longer lived by the believer at all, but by Christ in him.

Set that beside the experience of most of us and the gap is immediately painful. What we call normal is something else: a cycle of resolve and failure, of conferences that lift us and Mondays that flatten us, of sins confessed on Sunday and committed again by Wednesday. We have quietly redefined normal downward until it means *defeated*, and then we have comforted ourselves that everyone else is defeated too.

Nee's whole ministry was a protest against this redefinition. The New Testament standard, he insisted in *The Normal Christian Life*, is not an unreachable summit for the few. It is the ordinary birthright of every child of God. And the reason we do not enjoy it is not that we have not tried hard enough. It is that we have been trying at all.

The two halves of the problem

He built his case on Romans, and he made much of the way that letter is constructed. Romans divides at the end of chapter five. The first section, chapters one to five verse eleven, deals with one problem. The second section, chapter five verse twelve through chapter eight, deals with another. Most believers, he observed, have understood the first section and never entered the second.

The first problem is our *sins* — plural. The things we have done. The record against us. The guilt that lies on the conscience. For that problem God has provided the blood of Jesus Christ, and the language of that first section is the language of forgiveness, justification, remission, propitiation:

Whom God hath set forth to be a propitiation through faith in his blood, to declare his righteousness for the remission of sins that are past.

ROMANS 3:25

The second problem is our *sin* — singular. Not the acts but the nature that produces them. Not the fruit but the root. Not what we have done but what we are. And for that problem, Nee argued, blood is not the remedy at all. You cannot forgive a nature. You cannot pardon a disposition. Something must be done not *for* us but *to* us. The language changes accordingly:

Knowing this, that our old man is crucified with him, that the body of sin might be destroyed, that henceforth we should not serve sin.

ROMANS 6:6

Notice the verb. Not *shall be* crucified. Not *ought to be* crucified. *Is* crucified — and in the Greek, as an accomplished thing. The believer's old man was put to death when Christ was put to death. It happened. It is history.

Here, Nee said, is where nearly all our striving goes wrong. We treat Romans 6 as a command when it is an announcement. We read *reckon ye also yourselves to be dead indeed unto sin* and we set about trying to die. But no one is asked to die. We are asked to believe that we have died.

The great discovery is not effort but sight

There is a story Nee told in various forms over the years, of a young believer tormented by his failures, who came at last to Romans 6:6 and read it as though for the first time, and cried out that if it was true he did not need to die but only to see that he was dead already. That is the hinge of the whole matter.

Deliverance, in Nee's teaching, never comes by struggling. It comes by seeing. And seeing is not something a man can manufacture; it is something God gives. This is why he put such weight on the word *revelation* — not new truth beyond Scripture, but the Holy Spirit turning on the light in a believer's heart so that what was always written on the page becomes suddenly, personally, undeniably real. Paul prayed exactly for this:

That the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give unto you the spirit of wisdom and revelation in the knowledge of him: the eyes of your understanding being enlightened.

EPHESIANS 1:17–18

You may study Romans 6 for a decade and remain in bondage. You may see it in a moment and walk out free. The difference is not intelligence or effort. It is light.

What God has done, and what we are to do

Nee summarised the Christian's response to the finished work of Christ in a sequence of four words drawn straight from Romans 6, and the order is everything. *Know* — verse six. *Reckon* — verse eleven. *Present* — verse thirteen. *Obeys* — verse sixteen. The next several chapters of this book will follow that order, because getting it backwards is precisely what wrecks so many earnest believers. We attempt to present before we reckon, and to reckon before we know, and we end exhausted.

Everything begins with a fact outside ourselves. *But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us* (Romans 5:8). The Christian life is not the pursuit of a blessing we lack. It is the occupation of a position we already hold.

There is one further thing to say, and Nee said it constantly. This life is not self-improvement. It is substitution. The end of the process is not a better version of you. It is Christ living where you used to live.

Not I, but Christ.

Is this not perfectionism?

The objection arises immediately, and Nee met it directly. If the normal Christian life is Christ living in me, does that mean the believer no longer sins?

He answered no, and he was careful about why.

Nothing in his teaching suggests that the sinful nature is eradicated, or that a believer arrives at a settled condition in which temptation has no purchase. Romans 6 never says that sin is dead. It says that we died, and it then immediately warns us not to let sin reign — a warning that would be meaningless if sin were no longer present to reign.

My little children, these things write I unto you, that ye sin not. And if any man sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous.

1 JOHN 2:1

Notice how John holds both. The goal is that we sin not. The provision covers us when we do. Nee's teaching lives in exactly that space, and any presentation of it that promises a sinless condition has misrepresented him.

What he did claim is more modest and more useful. He claimed that sin need not be master. That the ordinary pattern of Christian experience should be deliverance rather than defeat. That a believer who is being overcome by the same thing year after year is not living as God intends, and should not accept it as inevitable.

He also insisted — and this is the safeguard against every form of perfectionism — that the deliverance is never a possession we hold independently of Christ. It is not a state achieved and then owned. It

is a moment-by-moment dependence. The branch does not store up sap for later; it draws continuously, and the moment it stops drawing it withers, however green it looked yesterday.

Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit of itself, except it abide in the vine; no more can ye, except ye abide in me.

JOHN 15:4

That is the difference between this teaching and any doctrine of attained holiness. The one produces a man who is confident in himself and blind to his condition. The other produces a man who knows he has nothing, and stays close to the One who has everything.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Write out, in your own words, the difference between your *sins* and your *sin*. Which of the two has your prayer life been mostly concerned with? Ask God to show you the other.
2. Read Romans chapters six to eight slowly, at one sitting, and underline every verb that describes something *already done*. Do not underline the commands yet. Look only at the facts.
3. Identify one besetting failure you have been fighting by willpower. Stop fighting it this week. Instead, bring Romans 6:6 to God each morning and ask Him to make it real to you rather than merely known.
4. Confess honestly to God any place where you have lowered your definition of the normal Christian life in order to accommodate your defeat.
5. Ask one mature believer to tell you what Galatians 2:20 has meant in their own experience. Listen without arguing.

A PRAYER

Father, I have been labouring to become what You say I already am. I have been trying to reach a place where You have already set me. Forgive me for the pride that would rather achieve than receive.

Open the eyes of my understanding. I do not ask for a new truth; I ask for light upon an old one. Show me the meaning of the cross, not as a doctrine I can explain, but as a fact that has happened to me.

Lord Jesus, I am content to be nothing if You will be everything. Live Your life in me today. Amen.

The Blood and the Cross

The blood of Jesus Christ his Son cleanseth us from all sin.

1 JOHN 1:7

If a man is to understand anything of Watchman Nee's teaching, he must first grasp a distinction that Nee drew more sharply than almost any teacher before him: the difference between the *blood* of Christ and the *cross* of Christ.

They are not two events. Calvary is one event. But it accomplishes two different things, addressed to two different problems, and applied in two different ways — and to confuse them is to remain permanently stuck.

The blood deals with what I have done

The blood, Nee taught, is Godward before it is manward. It is not primarily about how I feel; it is about how God is satisfied. Its first witness is not the sinner's peace but the righteousness of God.

And when I see the blood, I will pass over you.

EXODUS 12:13

Observe carefully what the Lord did not say to Israel in Egypt. He did not say, *when you see the blood*. He did not say, *when you feel confident about the blood*. He said, *when I see the blood*. The Israelite inside the house might be trembling; he might be doubting; he might have spent the night in an agony of uncertainty as to whether he had applied it properly. It made no difference whatever to his safety. The blood was on the door, and God was outside looking at it.

This is the ground of the believer's assurance, and Nee returned to it again and again in his gospel ministry and in *The Normal Christian Life*. Our forgiveness does not rest upon the quality of our repentance, the depth of our sorrow, or the steadiness of our faith. It rests upon a finished transaction which God has accepted.

Three things, he said, the blood accomplishes. It satisfies God — *it is the blood that maketh an atonement for the soul* (Leviticus 17:11). It cleanses the conscience — *how much more shall the blood of Christ ...purge your conscience from dead works* (Hebrews 9:14). And it silences the accuser — *they overcame him by the blood of the Lamb* (Revelation 12:11).

That last point deserves attention. Satan is called *the accuser of our brethren* (Revelation 12:10), and his accusations are frequently true. That is what makes them effective. Nee's counsel was not to argue with the accuser about the facts, nor to plead one's improvement, nor to promise to do better. It was to answer every accusation with the blood — to agree that the charge is true and to point to the payment. A debt truly incurred and truly settled is no longer a debt.

The cross deals with what I am

But now suppose a man has received full forgiveness for every sin he has ever committed, and his conscience is entirely at peace. He still has a problem. He will sin again tomorrow. Something in him wants to.

Blood cannot touch this. You cannot wash away a nature. The blood addresses the record; the cross addresses the man.

For he that is dead is freed from sin.

ROMANS 6:7

God's answer to what we are is not improvement, reformation or suppression. It is execution. *Our old man is crucified with him.* God did not send His Son to patch the old creation; He ended it, and began a new one.

Nee illustrated the difference with characteristic bluntness. If a man's clothes are dirty you wash them. If the man himself is incurably diseased, washing his clothes will not help; something must be done with the man. The blood washes; the cross crucifies. To ask the blood to do the cross's work is like asking soap to cure cancer.

Why the order cannot be reversed

There is a pastoral reason why Nee insisted on keeping these in sequence. Believers who reach for identification with Christ's death before they are settled in forgiveness will make the cross into a new form of works. They will try to crucify themselves in order to obtain acceptance — which is precisely the treadmill the gospel came to end.

First be sure of the blood. Rest wholly there. Let the conscience be purged and the accuser silenced. Then, standing on unshakeable ground, go on to discover what the cross has done with the old man.

Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ ...knowing this, that our old man is crucified with him.

ROMANS 5:1; 6:6

Peace first. Then deliverance. That is Paul's order, and Nee would not let his hearers reverse it.

One more observation, because it is easy to miss. Both the blood and the cross are things done *to us* and *for us*, not by us. The believer con-

tributes nothing to either but faith. There is no such thing, in Nee's teaching, as crucifying yourself. Men who attempt it are always found nailing one hand and leaving the other free.

A conscience that will not settle

There is a difficulty that arises for many earnest believers, and Nee dealt with it often, because it troubles the sincere far more than the careless.

A man confesses a sin. He knows the promise; he can quote it. And yet the accusation continues. Weeks later the memory surfaces and the old weight descends again, and he confesses once more, and once more, and the matter is never closed.

Nee's diagnosis was blunt: a conscience that keeps condemning what God has cleansed is not being humble. It is being unbelieving.

How much more shall the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered himself without spot to God, purge your conscience from dead works to serve the living God?

HEBREWS 9:14

The argument of Hebrews turns on this very point. The old sacrifices were repeated endlessly precisely because they could not settle the conscience — *for then would they not have ceased to be offered? because that the worshippers once purged should have had no more conscience of sins* (Hebrews 10:2). A finished work produces a settled conscience. If our consciences are never settled, it is because we are treating the work as unfinished.

He pointed also to Peter on the housetop, told three times to eat what he regarded as unclean, and given a rebuke that applies well beyond its original subject: *What God hath cleansed, that call not thou common* (Acts 10:15). To keep calling unclean what God has declared clean is not modesty. It is contradiction.

The practical counsel that followed was firm. Confess the sin once, thoroughly, naming it. Receive the cleansing. Make restitution where restitution is owed. And then refuse to reopen the file. When the memory returns, do not confess again; instead thank God that it has been dealt with, and turn your attention elsewhere.

Let us draw near with a true heart in full assurance of faith, having our hearts sprinkled from an evil conscience.

HEBREWS 10:22

Full assurance is not presumption. It is the intended result of the blood.

1. When accusation comes this week — and it will — practise answering it in one sentence: *That is true, and the blood of Jesus Christ has already paid for it.* Do not add promises of improvement.
2. Examine whether your assurance rests on the blood or on your own feelings. Note which one changed most recently.
3. Name one habit or attitude that no amount of forgiveness has ever cured. That is a matter for the cross, not the blood. Bring it to God as such.
4. Read Exodus 12 and Hebrews 9 together this week. Ask what God sees, not what you see.
5. If you have been trying to crucify yourself, stop. Confess it as unbelief, and rest in what was accomplished without you.

A PRAYER

Lord God, I thank You for the blood of Your Son. Not for my sorrow over sin, not for my resolutions, not for my religious performance — for the blood, and the blood alone.

When the accuser comes, teach me to plead nothing else. When my conscience condemns me, remind me that You are greater than my heart and that You have already been satisfied.

And Father, for the sin that lives in me still, show me the cross. I do not ask to be improved. I ask to be brought to an end, that Christ might live where I once did. Amen.

In Adam, In Christ

For as in Adam all die, even so in Christ shall all be made alive.

1 CORINTHIANS 15:22

Behind everything Nee taught about deliverance lies a single structural idea, and unless it is grasped the rest will not hold together. It is the idea of the two representative men.

How we got in

Ask a plain question: how did you become a sinner?

Most believers, if pressed, will answer that they became sinners by sinning. They committed acts of sin, and those acts made them sinners. Nee argued that this is exactly backwards, and that Romans 5 says so.

Wherefore, as by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin; and so death passed upon all men, for that all have sinned ...For as by one man's disobedience many were made sinners, so by the obedience of one shall many be made righteous.

ROMANS 5:12, 19

By one man's disobedience many were made sinners. Not by their own disobedience — by his. We did not become sinners by sinning; we sin because we were born sinners, and we were born sinners because we were in Adam when he fell.

Nee pressed the point with an image from Hebrews. The writer argues that Levi paid tithes to Melchizedek, though Levi was not born for generations, because *he was yet in the loins of his father, when Melchisedec met him* (Hebrews 7:10). Levi was there, in Abraham, and what Abraham did, Levi did.

So with the whole race. We were in Adam. His act was our act. His fall was our fall. This is not a legal fiction that God imposes on us from outside; it is a statement about where we actually were.

How we got out

Now the logic runs the other way, and this is the glory of it. If our ruin came by being *in* a man, our salvation comes the same way — by being *in* another Man.

But of him are ye in Christ Jesus, who of God is made unto us wisdom, and righteousness, and sanctification, and redemption.

1 CORINTHIANS 1:30

Of him are ye in Christ Jesus. It is God's doing. Nee loved to point out that no one has ever been able to explain how he got into Adam — and no one needs to explain how he got into Christ either. Both are acts of God, and both are equally real.

This is why the New Testament can say the extraordinary things it says about the believer. We were crucified with Him (Galatians 2:20). We were buried with Him (Romans 6:4). We were raised with Him (Colossians 3:1). We are seated with Him (Ephesians 2:6). These are not metaphors for our inner experience. They are statements of history. When Christ died, everyone who was in Him died. It could not be otherwise. You do not need to be nailed to a cross individually if you were in the Man who was.

Two creations, not one improved creation

Here Nee drove home the consequence that so many miss. God's method is not repair. It is replacement.

Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:17

The old creation in Adam is not being renovated. It has been judged, condemned and terminated at the cross, and a new creation has begun in the risen Christ. This is why self-improvement schemes, however sincere, are beside the point. God is not interested in a better Adam. He has no plans for Adam at all except burial.

Nee developed this contrast at length in works such as *The Glorious Church* and *Changed into His Likeness*, tracing it back to Genesis itself — the first Adam and his bride, the last Adam and His. But the practical edge of it is simple and searching. When you fail, you have two possible responses. You may set about mending the old man, which God has already refused to do. Or you may turn to the new position God has given you in Christ and stand there.

One caution, which Nee himself gave. To be in Christ is not to be absorbed into Christ, nor to lose our personality, nor to become divine. The believer remains a creature and a servant. What has changed is not our nature as human beings but our head, our race, our standing and our destiny. We have been transferred out of one man and into another.

Who hath delivered us from the power of darkness, and hath translated us into the kingdom of his dear Son.

COLOSSIANS 1:13

Translated. Moved. Carried across. It is the language of an accomplished migration, not an anticipated one.

The burial that declares it

Immediately before the great statement of Romans 6:6, Paul appeals to something his readers had all experienced.

Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death? Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death.

ROMANS 6:3–4

Nee made a good deal of this, and the point he drew from it is simple. We do not bury the living. Burial is what we do with those who have already died.

Baptism, therefore, is not a means of dying. It is the public acknowledgement of a death that has already taken place. The believer who goes down into the water is not attempting to end his old life; he is disposing of a body that is already a corpse in the reckoning of God. To treat baptism as a spiritual technique for achieving crucifixion is to reverse the order entirely.

This gave the ordinance a weight in his teaching that it does not always carry elsewhere. Baptism, on this understanding, is a believer's declaration before God, before the church, and — Nee would add — before the powers of darkness, that he has changed heads and changed races. He has come out of Adam. He belongs to another.

It also explains why Nee took the matter personally. Baptised as an infant in the Methodist church, he concluded after his conversion that this had not been his own act of faith at all, and in 1921 he was baptised by immersion. It cost him something in family standing. He regarded it as the first public act of a man who had been transferred.

Buried with him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with him through the faith of the operation of God, who hath raised him from the dead.

COLOSSIANS 2:12

Notice the balance in that verse: buried, and risen. Baptism is not a funeral only. The man who goes down comes up, and he comes up into a life that belongs to the new creation.

Christians differ over the mode and the subjects of baptism, and this book will not settle that. But whatever one's convictions there, the underlying doctrine stands and is worth recovering: the water testifies to a transfer that God has already accomplished.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Search out the phrase *in Christ* (and *in him, in whom*) through Ephesians chapter one. List everything that is said to be true of you there. Read the list aloud.

2. When you next fail, notice your instinctive response. Are you trying to mend Adam? Name it, and turn deliberately to your position in Christ instead.
3. Ask yourself honestly whether you believe your standing before God fluctuates with your performance. If it does in your feelings, tell God so, and ask Him to anchor you in fact.
4. Explain the two Adams to someone this month — a child, a new believer, a friend. Teaching it will expose whether you have grasped it.
5. Thank God specifically for a transfer you did not arrange and cannot undo.

A PRAYER

Father, I was born in Adam and I did not choose it. I have been placed in Christ and I did not achieve it. Both are Your doing, and I bow before both.

Teach me to stop expecting anything good from the man You have already crucified. Teach me to stop despairing over a nature You have already condemned. Let me look away from Adam altogether and look only at Your Son.

I am in Him. Nothing I do today can put me there, and nothing I do today can take me out. Let that settled place become the ground of everything I think and say and do. Amen.

Know

Knowing this, that our old man is crucified with him.

ROMANS 6:6

The first of the four words is *know*, and Nee would not allow anyone to move past it in a hurry. Everything that follows in Romans 6 depends upon it, and nothing that follows can be produced without it.

But we must be careful about what kind of knowing is meant, because there are two kinds, and only one of them saves anybody from anything.

Mental grasp and divine revelation

A man may know the doctrine of co-crucifixion perfectly well. He may be able to draw a diagram of it, distinguish it from other views of sanctification, expound the tense of the verb in verse six, and preach a serviceable sermon on it. And he may go home and lose his temper with his wife within the hour.

Nee spoke about this constantly, and it forms the substance of his little book *Spiritual Knowledge* and much of *Aids to Revelation*. There is knowledge that comes by study, and there is knowledge that comes by revelation, and they are not different amounts of the same thing. They are different in kind.

Blessed art thou, Simon Barjona: for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but my Father which is in heaven.

MATTHEW 16:17

Peter had said the right words. Others had said them too, or nearly. What the Lord commended was not the accuracy of the sentence but its source. It had not come up from below; it had come down from above.

This is why Nee taught believers to pray over their reading — not merely to pray before reading, as a pious formality, but to make the reading itself a matter of asking. The Bible is not a quarry from which the diligent extract truth by labour. It is a place where God speaks to those who wait.

Open thou mine eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of thy law.

PSALM 119:18

Why we cannot manufacture it

It follows that revelation cannot be worked up, and Nee was severe about attempts to counterfeit it. You cannot achieve sight by straining.

A blind man who squeezes his eyelids shut and concentrates furiously does not thereby see. He must have light given to him.

What then can a believer do? Nee's answer was: he can ask, and he can be honest, and he can wait.

He can ask, because the Lord commands it — *ask, and it shall be given you* (Matthew 7:7). He can be honest, because revelation is almost always withheld from a man who is unwilling to obey what he already sees. And he can wait, because God's timing is not ours, and the discovery that comes after long waiting is the one that lasts.

He was fond of noting that the great turning points in the lives of believers are rarely the result of a decision to understand. They come suddenly, often during something quite ordinary, and afterwards the person cannot say why he never saw it before, because now he cannot imagine how anyone could miss it. That is the signature of revelation. It does not feel like an achievement. It feels like the removal of something that was in the way.

What we are to know

And what are we to see? Precisely this: that we were included in the death of Jesus Christ.

Not that we ought to die. Not that we may die if we are sufficiently consecrated. That we *died* — finished, accomplished, done.

For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God.

COLOSSIANS 3:3

Nee illustrated it with the difference between a fact and a feeling. Suppose a man is told that a distant relative has died and left him an inheritance. He feels nothing at all; he never knew the relative. But the money is his, whether he feels rich or not. His feelings have no bearing on the estate. What he needs is not emotion but information — and then he must act on it.

So with our death in Christ. We do not feel dead. We feel painfully, obviously alive to sin. But the question God puts to us is not *how do you feel?* It is *do you know?*

There is a warning to add. Because Nee spoke so much of revelation, some who came after him made a mystique of it, waiting passively for experiences and neglecting the plain labour of reading, memorising and studying the Word. That was never his intention, and his own practice contradicts it. He was a disciplined and omnivorous reader who worked through the Scriptures relentlessly and read widely besides. Revelation does not replace study. It illuminates it. God generally turns on the light in rooms where somebody has been working.

Secondhand light

There is a particular hazard for anyone who reads widely or sits under good teaching, and Nee named it plainly.

It is possible to live on other people's revelation.

A believer hears a message that clearly came out of someone's real dealings with God. He is moved by it. He adopts the language, repeats the illustrations, and begins to teach it himself — having never once seen the thing for himself. What he passes on is a photograph of a meal. It is accurate. It will not nourish anybody.

Nee found the principle in the wilderness. The manna had to be gathered every morning by each household, and what was hoarded from the previous day did not keep.

Notwithstanding they hearkened not unto Moses; but some of them left of it until the morning, and it bred worms, and stank.

EXODUS 16:20

Yesterday's supply is not today's. And another man's supply is not mine.

This accounts, he suggested, for a good deal of preaching that is orthodox, well-arranged, and entirely without weight. The hearers can tell. There is a difference, immediately perceptible and impossible to counterfeit, between a man describing a country he has visited and a man reciting a guidebook.

The remedy is not to stop reading. Nee read constantly and urged others to. The remedy is to refuse to pass on as your own what God has not shown you, and to take what you have read back to God until He either confirms it to you or does not.

He suggested a discipline that is worth adopting. When a truth strikes you in someone else's book or sermon, do not immediately use it. Hold it. Bring it to God and ask Him to make it yours, and wait — for days or months if necessary. The truth that has passed through your own experience will come out of you with an authority that borrowed material never has.

That which we have seen and heard declare we unto you.

1 JOHN 1:3

Seen, and heard, and then declared. That is the apostolic order, and there is no shortcut through it.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Before your next Bible reading, ask God plainly for light rather than information. Note the difference in how you read.

2. Identify one truth you can explain but have never experienced. Bring that specific gap before God and ask Him to close it.
3. Check whether disobedience is blocking sight. Is there something you already know to be right and have not done? Do it first.
4. Set aside a longer period — an hour, an afternoon — with Romans 6 and nothing else. No commentary. Ask, and wait.
5. Record the date when God shows you something. Nee's generation kept such records; the memory of a real dealing with God is a strengthening thing in later drought.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have gathered much information about You, and I am not sure how much of it I have seen. I can explain doctrines that have never changed me. Have mercy on me.

You revealed Yourself to a fisherman who had no learning at all. Flesh and blood did not teach him. Father, teach me in the same way. Open my eyes.

I will not pretend to see what I do not see. But I will wait before You until You show me, and I will obey what You have already shown. Amen.

Reckon

Likewise reckon ye also yourselves to be dead indeed unto sin, but alive unto God through Jesus Christ our Lord.

ROMANS 6:11

The second word is *reckon*, and Nee spent a great deal of effort rescuing it from misuse, because it is one of the most misunderstood terms in the New Testament.

Reckoning is not pretending

To reckon, in the ordinary English of the Authorised Version, is to count, to calculate, to enter into the accounts. It is a bookkeeper's word. It means treating something as true because it is true.

What it does not mean is imagining. Nee warned repeatedly against the sort of teaching that tells a believer to repeat *I am dead, I am dead* until he feels dead, as though repetition could create a fact. That, he said plainly, is not faith; it is self-hypnotism, and it collapses at the first serious temptation.

The difference is the ground you are standing on. A man who reckons is standing on something God has said. A man who is pretending is standing on his own determination to believe. When the storm comes, the first man is still standing and the second is not.

So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.

ROMANS 10:17

This is why *know* must come before *reckon*. You cannot reckon on what you have not seen. Attempting it produces strain, and strain is the surest sign that something has gone wrong. Nee's rule of thumb was simple: if reckoning has become hard work, go back. You are trying to believe something you have not yet been shown.

Two accounts to keep

Notice that the verse has two halves, and Nee insisted on both.

Dead indeed unto sin — that is the negative side. *But alive unto God through Jesus Christ our Lord* — that is the positive. Christians who attend only to the first become preoccupied with death, introspective and gloomy, forever taking their own spiritual temperature. That is not the apostle's balance. The purpose of the death is the life. We are not

called to be corpses; we are called to be alive to God with an aliveness we did not previously possess.

Nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me.

GALATIANS 2:20

How reckoning works in a real temptation

Nee was practical about this, and it is worth setting out concretely, because here is where the doctrine either works or does not.

Temptation comes. The old response is to fight — to summon willpower, grit the teeth, resolve. And the more we fight in that way, the more the thing occupies our attention, and the more likely we are to fall. Every wrestler knows that the harder you grip your opponent, the more firmly he grips you.

The new response is to turn. Not to fight the sin, but to look away from it to Christ, and to hold the fact: *I died. The person to whom this appeal is being made no longer legally exists. I am not obliged to answer.*

Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body, that ye should obey it in the lusts thereof.

ROMANS 6:12

Observe that Paul does not say sin is dead. Sin is very much alive; that is why he tells us not to let it reign. What has died is not sin but us. Sin remains as a power in the world and a pull in the body, but its legal claim upon us has been dissolved by death, because *he that is dead is freed from sin* (Romans 6:7).

A creditor may shout as loudly as he likes at the grave of a debtor. The debt is uncollectable.

When we fail

What of the times we reckon and fall anyway? Nee's counsel here was full of common sense and free of condemnation. Failure does not disprove the fact. If a man falls out of a chair, the chair still exists.

When we fail, we do not go back to the beginning. We confess, receive cleansing by the blood — *if we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins* (1 John 1:9) — and we return to the same ground. The ground has not shifted. Our standing was never established by our success in standing.

Nee summed the matter up in a sentence that recurs in various forms across his ministry: it is not our reckoning that makes the thing true; it is because the thing is true that we may reckon.

Faith adds nothing to the facts. It simply consents to them.

Fact, faith and feeling

Nee used a picture here which had been current among deeper-life teachers before him and which he made his own. It concerns the order of three things.

Imagine three men walking along the top of a wall, in single file. The first is called Fact, the second Faith, and the third Feeling. So long as Faith keeps his eyes on Fact and walks steadily behind him, all three proceed safely, and Feeling follows without difficulty. But let Faith turn round to see how Feeling is getting on, and he loses sight of Fact — and Faith and Feeling both come off the wall together.

The point is about direction of gaze. Faith looks at fact. It does not look at feeling, and it certainly does not depend on it.

This is worth pressing, because the ordinary Christian instinct is exactly the reverse. We wake, we consult our sense of God's nearness, and we conclude from it whether things are well with us. On a morning when we feel warm towards God we believe we are in fellowship; on a flat morning we assume something is wrong. Nee regarded this as one of the most reliable ways to make a believer miserable.

For we walk by faith, not by sight.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:7

Feelings are not sinful, and Nee never taught that they were. God made the emotions, and Scripture is full of them. Joy is commanded. The point is one of sequence: feelings are a poor foundation and a fine result. They make an excellent caboose and a disastrous engine.

There is also a mercy in this. It means that a believer suffering from exhaustion, illness, grief or plain temperament is not thereby out of fellowship with God. His feelings may be flat for months. The facts have not moved an inch.

If we believe not, yet he abideth faithful: he cannot deny himself.

2 TIMOTHY 2:13

So the counsel is to establish what is true, stand on it deliberately, and let the emotions arrive in their own time — which, Nee observed, they generally do, though rarely on the schedule we would have chosen.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Distinguish this week between reckoning and pretending. When you assert your death with Christ, ask: on what am I standing — God's Word, or my own willpower?
2. In the next temptation, do not fight. Turn. Say to God honestly, *Lord, this is an appeal to a man who has died; I look to You.*

3. Attend to the positive half. Ask each morning not only to be dead to sin but alive to God, and name one specific way you want that aliveness to show.
4. If reckoning feels like strain, treat that as a signal rather than a failure. Go back and ask for light.
5. After a failure, practise returning to the same ground rather than starting again from despair. Write down now what you will say to yourself when you fall.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, I have tried to make things true by believing them hard enough, and I have worn myself out. Forgive me.

You have not asked me to create a fact. You have asked me to count on one. Let my faith rest where it belongs — not on the strength of my believing, but on the finished work of Your cross.

When temptation comes today, keep me from wrestling. Turn my eyes to You. I am dead to sin; I am alive to God; and both are true because You have said so. Amen.

Present

*Yield yourselves unto God, as those that are alive from the dead, and
your members as instruments of righteousness unto God.*

ROMANS 6:13

The third word is *present*, or as the Authorised Version has it, *yield*. Here the teaching turns from what God has done to what the believer must decide.

Nee was insistent about the order. Consecration comes after knowing and reckoning, not before. This runs against the grain of a great deal of preaching, which begins with the appeal for surrender and applies it to people who have no idea what they are surrendering or on what basis. The result is a familiar and demoralising pattern: an emotional response at a meeting, a genuine intention, a few weeks of effort, and then a return to the old life with an added sense of failure.

Why does it fail? Because the man is offering to God something God has already condemned. He is presenting the old man for service. And God has no use for Adam, however sincerely Adam offers himself.

Consecration is a response to a fact

The consecration Romans 6 asks for is offered by a particular sort of person: *as those that are alive from the dead*. Not those trying to die. Those who have died and been raised.

I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service.

ROMANS 12:1

By the mercies of God. Paul spends eleven chapters describing what God has done before he asks for anything. The appeal rests upon the argument. Nee drew a straight line here: consecration is never the price of blessing; it is the response to blessing already received.

He put it in terms of ownership. If a man buys a house, the house is his by right of purchase, whether or not the previous occupant hands over the keys. But until the keys are handed over, the owner cannot use what belongs to him. Consecration is the handing over of keys to a Proprietor who has already paid.

What? know ye not that your body is the temple of the Holy Ghost which is in you, which ye have of God, and ye are not your own? For ye are bought with a price.

Ye are not your own. It is not a request for a loan. It is notice of a change of ownership that has already occurred.

Once for all, and then daily

There is a paradox in Nee's treatment which he never tried to resolve, because Scripture does not resolve it either. Consecration is a definite act, and it is also a continual condition.

The definite act matters. He often urged believers to a decisive transaction with God — a particular day, a particular prayer, a line drawn — and he observed that many believers drift for years precisely because they have never made one. The Levites were consecrated on a specific day. The burnt offering was laid on the altar at a specific hour.

But the offering laid on the altar was also, in the nature of things, consumed daily. So Paul speaks of a *living* sacrifice — a phrase which, as generations of preachers have noticed, contains its own difficulty, since a living sacrifice may always climb down off the altar.

Nee's counsel was to make the transaction once and then to maintain it by successive small obediences. The great surrender is settled in a moment. It is worked out in the question of what you do with an evening, a grudge, a sum of money, an ambition.

The members

Note the specificity of the text. Paul does not ask for a vague spiritual dedication. He asks for the *members* — the actual parts of the actual body — to be handed over as instruments.

Nee took this concretely. The tongue is a member; is it an instrument of righteousness or of sin? The eyes are members. The hands, the feet, the ears. The mind. The money, which is the stored labour of the hands. Consecration that never reaches the members is a sentiment, not a sacrifice.

In the Kuling trainings of 1948 and 1949 he pressed this to its practical conclusion, calling believers to hand over their possessions, homes and livelihoods to the Lord's disposal. Many did, at real cost. Whatever one makes of the particular form that movement took, the principle behind it is unarguably apostolic: a Lord who owns you owns your things.

One last word, and it is a liberating one. God does not ask us to make ourselves useful before He will accept the offering. The altar sanctifies the gift, not the reverse. Bring what you are, not what you hope to become.

When God asks for Isaac

Consecration is easy in general and difficult in particular. Nee knew this, and he returned repeatedly to the moment where the general becomes particular.

Take now thy son, thine only son Isaac, whom thou lovest, and get thee into the land of Moriah; and offer him there for a burnt offering.

GENESIS 22:2

He drew out something about this demand that is easy to miss and, once seen, hard to forget. Isaac was not Abraham's achievement. Isaac was God's own gift — the promised son, born to a couple long past hope, the very pledge of everything God had covenanted. And it was this, precisely this, that God asked for back.

Nee's application, developed at length in *Changed into His Likeness*, was that God frequently requires from us the thing He Himself gave. Not our sins, which we should be glad to surrender, but our blessings. The ministry He raised up. The child. The health. The work into which we poured thirty years.

Why? Because a gift can take the place of the Giver, and it usually does. What Abraham was being asked to give up was not a boy; it was a dependence that had attached itself to the promise rather than to the One who promised.

This is where consecration is actually tested. Most of us are willing enough for God to have our failures. The question is whether He may have the one thing we have quietly decided He may not ask for — and every honest believer knows what that thing is, usually within a few seconds of being asked.

Nee added an observation of great pastoral value. Abraham received Isaac back. The knife was raised and the hand was stopped, and what came down the mountain was a father and a son who now belonged to God rather than to each other. In most cases, he said, God does not take the thing; He takes our grip on it. But He will not settle for less than the raised knife, because a surrender with conditions attached is not a surrender.

Now I know that thou fearest God, seeing thou hast not withheld thy son, thine only son from me.

GENESIS 22:12

Now I know. Something was established on that mountain that could not have been established anywhere else.

1. If you have never made a definite transaction of consecration with God, make one. Set a date. Write it down. Tell someone.
2. Go through your members one by one — eyes, tongue, hands, mind, time, money — and name for each a specific way it is currently an instrument of unrighteousness. Present each one deliberately.
3. Check the foundation. Are you consecrating in order to gain God's favour, or because you already have it? Only the second will last.
4. Identify one thing you are holding that is not yours: a resentment, a possession, a plan for your life. Hand over the keys.
5. Ask God to show you tomorrow's small obedience, and do that one thing rather than making a large new resolution.

A PRAYER

Father, You have bought me. I did not set the price and I cannot revoke the sale. I am not my own.

I have kept back rooms in a house that belongs to You. Today I hand over the keys — not to earn anything, for You have already given me everything, but because it is Yours and I have been withholding it.

Take my body. Take my tongue, my eyes, my hands, my hours, my money, my ambitions. I lay them on Your altar, and I ask You to keep them there when I am tempted to climb down. Amen.

The Spirit of Life

For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus hath made me free from the law of sin and death.

ROMANS 8:2

Romans 7 is the most uncomfortable chapter in the Bible for anyone who has ever tried to be good.

Here is a man who wants what is right, who delights in the law of God after the inward man, who hates what he does — and who cannot do the thing he wants. He is not a rebel. He is a sincere, earnest, thoroughly defeated believer. And Nee made much of the fact that the chapter is dense with the first person singular. Count the times *I*, *me* and *my* occur in those verses; it is a great many. That, he said, is the whole problem in a single grammatical observation. Romans 7 is the biography of a Christian trying to serve God by himself.

For I know that in me (that is, in my flesh,) dwelleth no good thing: for to will is present with me; but how to perform that which is good I find not.

ROMANS 7:18

Nee observed something that is easy to miss. The great discovery of Romans 7 is not that I am a sinner — the man knew that already. It is that I am *helpless*. And God allows the experience of chapter seven precisely in order to bring us to the end of our own resources, because until a man knows he cannot, he will not stop trying.

Two laws, and how one defeats the other

The way out is not more effort. It is another law.

The law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus hath made me free from the law of sin and death. Nee used the illustration of gravity. A stone falls because of a law; you cannot argue with it, and you cannot suspend it by resolution. But a bird rises, because a higher law — the law of life — is at work in it. The law of gravity has not been repealed. It has been overcome by something stronger.

So deliverance is not the removal of the flesh, nor the improvement of the will. It is the operation of a life that is not ours.

Two aspects of one Spirit

Here Nee introduced a distinction he considered vital, and which he treated at length in *The Normal Christian Life* and in *The Communion of the Holy Spirit*. The Holy Spirit is given to the believer in two aspects.

There is the Spirit *within* — the indwelling Spirit, given to every believer at the new birth, whose work is life, transformation and the production of Christ's character.

Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his.

ROMANS 8:9

And there is the Spirit *upon* — the outpoured Spirit, whose work is power and equipment for service and testimony.

But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me.

ACTS 1:8

The two are not the same, Nee argued, and confusing them causes real damage in both directions. Some believers seek power when what they need is life, and become noisy and fruitless. Others, having tasted the inward work, despise the outward and remain ineffective in service.

He was careful, though, about how the second is obtained. It is not a reward for spiritual attainment, and it is not extracted from God by fasting or pleading. It is, like everything else in his teaching, already given, and to be received. The Spirit was poured out at Pentecost upon the whole Body; the individual believer does not ask God to do it again but takes his share in what has been done.

Therefore being by the right hand of God exalted, and having received of the Father the promise of the Holy Ghost, he hath shed forth this, which ye now see and hear.

ACTS 2:33

The condition

If the Spirit's fullness is not earned, is there any condition at all? Nee answered that there is one, and it is not spiritual excellence. It is obedience.

And we are his witnesses of these things; and so is also the Holy Ghost, whom God hath given to them that obey him.

ACTS 5:32

The Spirit is not given to the worthy but to the willing. And because the Spirit is a Person and not a force, the practical question of the Christian life is not how to use Him but how not to grieve Him.

And grieve not the holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are sealed unto the day of redemption.

EPHESIANS 4:30

Nee taught believers to attend to the inward sense — that quiet checking, that absence of peace, which is the Spirit's ordinary way of guiding a consecrated heart. Not a voice, not a sign, not a hunch dignified with

religious language, but a settled inward witness that either presses forward or holds back. Learning to obey that check in small matters is, he said, the whole training of the spiritual life.

A word of balance. Because Nee spoke of an inward sense, some readers have made subjective impressions into an authority that overrides Scripture. That is a serious error, and it is not his. The Spirit who speaks within is the same Spirit who wrote the Word, and He does not contradict Himself. Where the inward sense and the plain teaching of Scripture appear to disagree, Scripture governs — every time, without exception.

Flesh and Spirit, day by day

Romans 8 describes the position. Galatians 5 describes the daily experience of it, and Nee treated the two together.

This I say then, Walk in the Spirit, and ye shall not fulfil the lust of the flesh. For the flesh lusteth against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh: and these are contrary the one to the other.

GALATIANS 5:16–17

Two things in that passage governed his teaching.

First, the conflict is normal. A believer who finds two contrary pulls within him is not thereby unspiritual; he is thereby alive. The unregenerate man has no such civil war, because there is only one party in the field. The presence of the struggle is evidence of the Spirit's arrival, not of His absence.

Second — and this is the practical point — the command is not *fight the flesh*. It is *walk in the Spirit*, with the promise attached that the other thing will not then be fulfilled. The negative is achieved by the positive. Nee compared it to a room full of stale air. You may attempt to remove the darkness with a shovel, or you may open the shutters. Light does not have to fight darkness; it only has to be admitted.

This reframes the whole business of temptation. The question in the moment is not *how do I suppress this?* but *what does walking in the Spirit look like in the next five minutes?* Sometimes the answer is prayer. Often it is something quite unspiritual-looking: doing the next duty, leaving the room, telephoning a brother, going to bed.

He drew the same conclusion about Christian character. The virtues of Galatians 5:22–23 are called *fruit*, not achievements, and fruit is grown rather than manufactured. Nobody produces patience by resolving to be patient; the tree produces it, given root, light and time.

But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, meekness, temperance: against such there is no law.

GALATIANS 5:22–23

Note that it is fruit, singular, with nine descriptions — one life expressing itself in nine directions. You do not select among them. Where the life is present, the whole cluster eventually appears.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Count the personal pronouns in Romans 7:14–25 for yourself. Ask whether your own prayers sound more like Romans 7 or Romans 8.
2. Have you come to the end of trying? If not, ask God to bring you there; it is a mercy, not a punishment.
3. Distinguish in your own experience between needing life and needing power. Which have you been seeking, and which do you actually lack?
4. Practise obeying the inward check this week in one small matter — a word not spoken, a purchase not made. Small obediences train the ear.
5. Test every inward impression against Scripture. Where the two conflict, submit to the Word without negotiation.

A PRAYER

Holy Spirit, I have tried to live the Christian life with my own strength and I have failed exactly as Scripture said I would. I am not merely guilty; I am helpless. I confess it.

Be in me the law of life that overcomes the law of sin. Do in me what I cannot do for myself.

And clothe me with what I need for service, not because I deserve it, but because Christ has been exalted and has poured it out. Make me quick to obey Your least restraint, and keep me from grieving You today. Amen.

Sit

And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus.

EPHESIANS 2:6

Among all Nee's books, the shortest is arguably the most perfectly constructed. *Sit, Walk, Stand* takes the letter to the Ephesians and finds in it three words that mark its three movements: our position before God, our life in the world, and our attitude towards the enemy.

And the order is not negotiable. Everything hangs on beginning in the right place.

Christianity begins with a chair

The natural religious instinct is to begin with walking — with conduct, effort, duty. Nee's contention is that the Christian life begins with sitting down.

Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ, (by grace ye are saved;) and hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus.

EPHESIANS 2:5–6

Sitting, he pointed out, is the posture of one whose work is done. We do not sit down to a task; we sit down after it. And the striking thing about Ephesians 2 is that the sitting has already happened, and it happened to people who were at the time *dead in sins* and contributed precisely nothing to it.

He drew out a comparison with creation. Man was made on the sixth day and his first full day of existence was the seventh — the day of God's rest. Man did not work six days and then rest; he began in a rest that God had already entered. So the believer begins his Christian life at the point of God's completed work, not at the beginning of his own.

There remaineth therefore a rest to the people of God. For he that is entered into his rest, he also hath ceased from his own works, as God did from his.

HEBREWS 4:9–10

Not resting from work, but working from rest

Nee was quick to guard the point against the obvious misreading. To sit is not to be idle. The Christian works — Ephesians itself is full of instruction about conduct, family, labour and warfare. The question is not whether we work but where the work starts.

The difference is between working *towards* a position and working *from* one. A man who is trying to earn his acceptance labours under an anxiety that never lifts, because there is always more to do. A man who has been seated labours out of a security he did not create and cannot lose.

He was fond of the picture of a man on a boat. If he tries to push the boat along, he exhausts himself and it barely moves. If he sits down and lets the current carry him, he arrives. The strength required to be carried is nil, but one must actually sit.

The gift and the giving up

There is a cost to sitting, and Nee did not hide it. It is the cost of abandoning the satisfaction of having contributed.

We would rather help. There is something in every one of us — and it is the oldest thing in us — that would prefer a salvation we had a hand in. To sit down is to admit that the whole thing was done without us, and there is a humbling in that which many believers avoid for years by staying busy.

For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: not of works, lest any man should boast.

EPHESIANS 2:8–9

Where the chair is

One more detail Nee would not let pass: *in heavenly places*. The believer's seat is not on earth. It is above — in the place where Christ is, at the right hand of God, *far above all principality, and power, and might, and dominion* (Ephesians 1:21).

This matters enormously for what comes later. The Christian does not fight his way up to victory; he views the battle from above it. He does not struggle to reach a place of authority; he is already seated with the One who has it. Every question of warfare in chapter six will be settled by what was established in chapter two.

Sit is the first word, and it is the one that most of us skip. If your Christian life is marked by chronic tiredness — not the honest tiredness of labour, but the grey exhaustion of never having arrived — the problem is almost certainly here. You have been walking without having sat down.

Martha's kitchen

Nee was fond of the scene at Bethany, and used it to make a distinction that cuts across most of our assumptions about Christian service.

But Martha was cumbered about much serving ... But one thing is needful: and Mary hath chosen that good part, which shall not be taken away from her.

LUKE 10:40, 42

The striking thing, he observed, is that Martha was not doing anything wrong. She was serving Jesus. The meal needed cooking; somebody had to cook it; the guest was the Son of God and the hospitality was genuine. If we are honest, most of us would rather have Martha in our congregation than Mary.

What was wrong was not the work but its source. Martha was *cumbered* — the word suggests being dragged about, pulled in several directions. And the symptom appeared, as it always does, in her speech: she complained about her sister, and she reproached the Lord for not noticing. Service that comes out of restlessness reliably produces resentment towards those who are not serving.

Nee's application was uncomfortable for active people. A great deal of Christian work, he said, is Martha's work: undertaken for the Lord, but not out of rest, and therefore carrying an undertone of strain, comparison and self-justification that everyone around can feel.

The alternative is not idleness. Mary is not commended for being lazy; she is commended for having chosen the one needful thing, and the order matters. Elsewhere in the Gospels Mary of Bethany is the one who anoints the Lord for His burial — an act of service so costly that it was criticised, and so perceptive that He defended it. The woman who sat became the woman who understood, and the woman who understood gave the most.

Sitting, in other words, does not reduce service. It changes where service comes from, and it changes what service is worth.

It is vain for you to rise up early, to sit up late, to eat the bread of sorrows: for so he giveth his beloved sleep.

PSALM 127:2

Nee's test was simple, and it is worth applying honestly. Does your service leave you resenting the people who are not doing it? If so, the problem is probably not their idleness. It is the place your own labour is starting from.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask yourself plainly: am I working towards God's acceptance or from it? Your answer will show in how you feel after a day of failure.
2. Take Ephesians 1 and 2 and mark every verb whose subject is God. Notice how few of them have you as the subject.
3. Name one activity in your ministry or service that you are doing out of anxiety rather than rest. Consider whether God asked for it.
4. Practise a deliberate sitting: take fifteen minutes to receive rather than to petition. Say nothing. Simply consent to what has been

done.

5. Where you are facing opposition, remind yourself where your seat is — above it, not beneath it.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have been trying to reach a place You have already given me. I have been labouring towards a rest You entered without my help.

Forgive the pride that would rather assist than receive. I lay down the satisfaction of having contributed.

Teach me to sit — not in idleness, but in the finished work of Christ. And from that seat, let all my labour begin. Amen.

Walk

I therefore, the prisoner of the Lord, beseech you that ye walk worthy of the vocation wherewith ye are called.

EPHESIANS 4:1

The letter turns at chapter four. Having spent three chapters describing what God has done, Paul says *therefore* — and for the next two chapters he deals with conduct.

Nee's point about this hinge is simple and important: the *therefore* is load-bearing. Christian behaviour is not a set of requirements imposed upon us in order to make us acceptable. It is the appropriate outworking of a position already occupied. We do not walk in order to sit. We walk because we are seated.

Worthy of a calling, not worthy of a wage

Note the phrase: *walk worthy of the vocation wherewith ye are called*. Not worthy of God — no one is. Worthy of the calling. There is a fittingness being asked for, the way a man's clothing should suit the occasion he has been invited to.

That ye put off concerning the former conversation the old man, which is corrupt according to the deceitful lusts; and be renewed in the spirit of your mind; and that ye put on the new man, which after God is created in righteousness and true holiness.

EPHESIANS 4:22–24

Nee laid weight on the metaphor of clothing. Putting off and putting on are not the same as killing and creating. The old man was crucified — that was settled at the cross and is not repeated. What we do daily is decline to wear him. The garment is discarded, not the corpse re-executed.

This distinction saved a great many of his hearers from a wearying spiritual practice in which every day begins with an attempt to die all over again. The death is behind us. The wardrobe choice is in front of us.

The walk is with others

There is something easily overlooked in Ephesians 4 to 6 which Nee never overlooked: almost every instruction concerns another person.

Lying is forbidden because *we are members one of another* (Ephesians 4:25). Anger must not be carried overnight. Stealing is replaced

by working so that there may be something to give away. Corrupt speech is replaced by speech that builds up the hearer. Bitterness, wrath, clamour and evil speaking are to be put away, and in their place: *be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you* (Ephesians 4:32).

Then follow the household relationships — husbands and wives, parents and children, servants and masters. Nee found this deeply significant. The deeper life is not tested in the prayer closet, where no one contradicts us. It is tested at the table, in the marriage, in the workshop, in the way a man speaks to those who cannot answer him back.

He had little patience for spirituality that flourished in meetings and collapsed at home. The measure of a man's walk, he taught, is taken by the people who live with him.

Walking in love, in light, and carefully

Ephesians 5 gives the walk three qualities, and Nee treated them in turn.

Walk in love (5:2) — and the standard given is Christ's self-giving, not our natural affection. Love here is measured by what it costs, not by what it feels.

Walk as children of light (5:8) — which chiefly means transparency. The believer has nothing to hide, and the willingness to be known is itself a form of holiness. *But all things that are reprov'd are made manifest by the light* (5:13).

Walk circumspectly (5:15) — literally, accurately; walking as a man does who is picking his way across broken ground. Nee connected this to the redeeming of time: *because the days are evil* (5:16). A short life in a dark age is not to be spent carelessly.

And through all of it, the enabling is the same as the beginning. *Be filled with the Spirit* (5:18) stands in the middle of these instructions, not as one more command among many, but as the power by which the rest become possible. Nee's whole point is that Christian conduct is Christ's life reaching the surface. Where it is anything else — willpower, temperament, culture, fear of what people will say — it may look similar for a while, but it will not hold.

The renewing of the mind

Between the position and the walk, Paul places one more thing, and Nee would not let it be skipped.

And be not conformed to this world: but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind, that ye may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect, will of God.

Conformity, he pointed out, happens by default. It requires no decision. A body placed in a mould takes the shape of the mould simply by remaining there, and a believer immersed in the assumptions of his age will absorb them without ever consciously adopting one of them. The world does not usually argue us out of our convictions. It simply makes certain things unthinkable and other things obvious, and we adjust.

Transformation, by contrast, works in the opposite direction — from within outwards — and it operates through the mind.

This is why Nee gave such weight to the sustained reading of Scripture. Not reading for sermon material, and not reading to complete a schedule, but the slow saturation by which a man's instinctive judgments begin to change. The renewed mind is not merely a mind with more information in it. It is a mind that has come to find different things obvious.

And be renewed in the spirit of your mind.

EPHESIANS 4:23

He noted the practical outcome Paul attaches to it: *that ye may prove what is ...the will of God*. Guidance, on this understanding, is far less often a matter of special direction than of a mind so shaped by God that it recognises His will when it appears. The believer who is forever asking for signs may be revealing that the ordinary means have been neglected.

There is a test in this that anyone can apply. Take an area where the culture around you holds a settled opinion — about money, about status, about forgiveness, about who deserves respect. Ask what Scripture says. Then ask which of the two your gut agrees with. The gap between them is the measure of how much renewing remains to be done.

Nee's expectation was that this work is gradual and mostly invisible, and that it shows up not in what we say we believe but in what we do without thinking.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask the people you live with, not the people you minister to, how your walk is going. Their answer is the accurate one.
2. Identify one garment of the old man you have kept in the wardrobe — a habit of speech, a way of handling conflict. Take it off deliberately today rather than trying to die again.
3. Take Ephesians 4:25–32 and find the one command you break most often. Confess it as an offence against the Body, which is how Paul frames it.

4. Examine your speech for one week with a single question: did that build up the person who heard it?
5. Where are you walking carelessly with your time? Name one specific redemption of an hour, and make it this week.

A PRAYER

Father, You have seated me in Christ, and now You ask me to walk in a manner that suits it. I confess how often my conduct has contradicted my position.

Let my holiness be tested where it counts — in my home, with my family, among those who can do nothing for me. Guard my tongue. Take the bitterness out of me before the sun goes down.

I cannot produce this by resolve. Fill me with Your Spirit, and let Your own life come to the surface in the ordinary hours of this day. Amen.

Stand

*Wherefore take unto you the whole armour of God, that ye may be able
to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand.*

EPHESIANS 6:13

The third movement of Ephesians is warfare, and Nee's treatment of it in *Sit, Walk, Stand* turns on a single observation about the vocabulary.

Paul does not tell us to attack. He does not tell us to advance, to storm, to conquer or to take ground. Four times in a few verses he uses one word: *stand*. Withstand, and having done all, stand. Stand therefore. Having done all, stand.

You do not tell a soldier to hold his position unless the position is already his.

Fighting from victory, not for it

This is the whole of Nee's doctrine of warfare, and it is simply chapter two applied to chapter six. The believer is seated with Christ *far above all principality, and power, and might, and dominion* (Ephesians 1:21). The battle was fought and settled at the cross and the resurrection.

*And having spoiled principalities and powers, he made a shew of them openly,
triumphing over them in it.*

COLOSSIANS 2:15

Having spoiled. Past. Finished. The enemy is a defeated enemy. What remains is not a war to be won but a victory to be maintained against a foe who does not accept the result.

Nee's practical conclusion follows: the Christian never prays for victory. He prays from it. To ask God to defeat the devil is, in his blunt phrasing, to ask God to do again what He has already done, and it betrays that we have not yet believed the report of the first battle.

The enemy's chief weapon is a lie

If the ground is already ours, how does the enemy take it back? By persuading us that it is not.

Nee identified the primary battlefield as the mind, and pointed to the armour itself as evidence. The helmet is salvation — protection for the head, the place of thought. The shield of faith quenches *the fiery darts of the wicked* (Ephesians 6:16), which are precisely injected thoughts:

suggestions of doubt, accusation, despair, suspicion of God and of one another.

Casting down imaginations, and every high thing that exalteth itself against the knowledge of God, and bringing into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ.

2 CORINTHIANS 10:5

He taught believers to recognise thoughts that do not originate with them. A sudden, alien, insistent accusation — *God has abandoned you, you are finished, that brother despises you* — may not be a conviction from the Spirit at all. Nee's test was characteristically simple: the Holy Spirit convicts of specific sin in order to bring us to the cross, and His conviction leaves us with hope and a way forward. The accuser condemns the person in general terms and leaves us with despair and no way forward. Learn the difference and half the battle is over.

The armour is a Person

Nee also noted that every piece of the armour is elsewhere in Scripture attributed to Christ Himself. He is our righteousness, our peace, our salvation, our truth. To put on the armour is not to acquire seven spiritual accessories. It is to put on Christ.

But put ye on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make not provision for the flesh, to fulfil the lusts thereof.

ROMANS 13:14

And note what is left unprotected. There is no armour for the back. The soldier who turns to flee is defenceless, which is another way of saying the same thing: the only safety is in standing.

The place of prayer

The passage ends not with a weapon but with a posture: *praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit* (Ephesians 6:18). Nee took this as the point at which the armour is actually worn. Doctrine about warfare that does not issue in prayer is theory. The church that argues about spiritual authority and does not pray has none.

A caution, since this territory attracts excess. Nee's own emphasis is remarkably sober. He does not encourage believers to seek out confrontations with evil powers, to catalogue them, or to make the enemy a preoccupation. Elsewhere he warned that undue attention to Satan is itself a victory for Satan, and that the safest Christian is the one occupied with Christ. Stand your ground, resist when resisted, and keep your eyes on the Lord.

Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.

JAMES 4:7

Submission comes first in that verse. It always does.

Giving place

If the enemy's claim is illegitimate, how does he obtain a foothold in the life of a believer at all? Paul answers in a passage Nee cited frequently, and the answer is startling in its ordinariness.

Be ye angry, and sin not: let not the sun go down upon your wrath: neither give place to the devil.

EPHESIANS 4:26–27

Give place. The word suggests granting ground, allowing an opening. And the context is not occultism, nor gross immorality, nor anything a congregation would recognise as dramatic. It is a quarrel carried overnight.

Nee's conclusion was that the enemy's ordinary access to a Christian is through unforgiveness. Not through curses or rituals, but through resentment that has been kept, justified and nursed — usually with excellent reasons, since the grievance is generally real.

He connected this to the Lord's own warning at the end of the parable of the unforgiving servant, and to the clause in the prayer He taught us, which is the only petition He returned to afterwards and explained.

For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: but if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.

MATTHEW 6:14–15

The practical counsel was direct. Where you have been standing without result — praying, resisting, and finding no ground gained — look first for something you are holding. Not something being done to you, but something you are keeping. Forgiveness, he taught, is not a feeling to be waited for but a decision to be made and then maintained, frequently against the feelings, sometimes for years.

He was careful to distinguish forgiveness from three things it is often confused with. It is not saying the wrong did not matter. It is not the restoration of trust, which must be earned. And it is not the removal of consequences, which may rightly continue. It is the surrender of one's claim to repayment — handing the debt over to God, who alone can settle it justly.

Dearly beloved, avenge not yourselves ...for it is written, Vengeance is mine; I will repay, saith the Lord.

ROMANS 12:19

The ground closes the moment the claim is released.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Change the grammar of your praying. Instead of asking God for victory, thank Him for the victory Christ has already won, and hold your ground.
2. Learn to distinguish conviction from accusation. Write the two tests down and keep them where you pray.
3. When an alien thought arrives, do not argue with it and do not accept it. Answer it with a specific verse and move on.
4. Check whether you have turned your back on any ground — a relationship, a besetting sin, a calling — because standing became costly. Return and stand.
5. Do not study the enemy. Study Christ. Notice this week how much of your attention each receives.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You met the enemy at the cross and You triumphed openly. I did not help, and I cannot improve upon it.

Forgive me for praying as though the outcome were still in doubt. Teach me to stand on ground You purchased with Your blood.

Guard my mind today. When accusation comes disguised as conviction, give me discernment. When the darts come, let faith be my shield. And keep me looking at You, not at him. Amen.

Spirit, Soul and Body

And the very God of peace sanctify you wholly; and I pray God your whole spirit and soul and body be preserved blameless unto the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:23

In 1928, gravely ill with tuberculosis and expecting to die, Watchman Nee published his first substantial work. *The Spiritual Man* runs to three volumes and sets out an anatomy of the inner life that shaped everything he afterwards taught.

Its central proposition is that man is not two parts but three.

The threefold constitution

For the word of God is quick, and powerful, and sharper than any twoedged sword, piercing even to the dividing asunder of soul and spirit, and of the joints and marrow.

HEBREWS 4:12

Nee read Paul's benediction in 1 Thessalonians 5:23 and this verse in Hebrews as teaching a real distinction between spirit and soul. The *body* is that by which we relate to the physical world. The *soul* is the seat of personality — mind, emotion and will; it is what makes a man himself, and it is by the soul that he relates to other people and to his own inner world. The *spirit* is the innermost part, by which alone a man relates to God.

He found the pattern in Genesis: *the Lord God formed man of the dust of the ground — the body; and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life — the spirit; and man became a living soul — the personality produced by the union of the two* (Genesis 2:7).

At the fall, he argued, the spirit died in the sense that it lost its communication with God, and man became soul-governed — ruled by his own mind, feelings and will rather than by God through the spirit. Regeneration is precisely the quickening of the spirit.

That which is born of the flesh is flesh; and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.

JOHN 3:6

Why the distinction matters practically

One might think this a piece of technical anthropology of no use to an ordinary believer. Nee thought otherwise, and his reason is worth understanding.

If a man cannot tell the difference between what rises from his soul and what comes from his spirit, he will confuse emotion with the presence of God, mental clarity with revelation, and strength of will with faith. He will conclude he has been near to God because he was moved, and that God has departed because he feels flat.

But the natural man receiveth not the things of the Spirit of God: for they are foolishness unto him: neither can he know them, because they are spiritually discerned.

1 CORINTHIANS 2:14

The word rendered *natural* there is, in the Greek, the soulish man — the man whose life is governed by the soul. Nee's contention is that a genuine believer may nonetheless live a soulish Christian life: sincere, active, emotional, intelligent, and yet not walking by the Spirit at all.

The remedy is discernment, and the instrument of discernment is the Word of God, which pierces to the dividing asunder of soul and spirit. Only Scripture can make that cut. We cannot make it ourselves by introspection — indeed introspection is a soulish activity and tends to deepen the problem.

Handle with care

Honesty requires a caution here, and Nee himself supplied part of it.

Not all Bible teachers accept the trichotomy. Many careful expositors hold that Scripture uses *spirit* and *soul* largely interchangeably, that the Hebrews 4:12 passage speaks of the depth of the Word's penetration rather than of a clean anatomical line, and that man is best understood as a unity viewed from different angles. That position is held by godly and serious readers of Scripture, and a believer who takes it loses nothing essential.

Nee later grew uneasy about the systematising in *The Spiritual Man*. He is reported to have regretted the analytical thoroughness of it, on the grounds that readers were turning a description of spiritual experience into a technique for self-examination — which is exactly the soulishness the book was written to expose.

That is the right way to hold this chapter. Take the pastoral insight, which is genuine and valuable: much that passes for spirituality is merely refined human life, and we need God to show us the difference. Leave the elaborate diagrams alone. A believer preoccupied with locating the boundary between his soul and his spirit has already lost the plot.

Three functions of the human spirit

Within his account of the spirit, Nee distinguished three operations, and this part of *The Spiritual Man* has proved more durable than the

anatomy itself. Whatever one concludes about trichotomy, these three are recognisable in Christian experience.

The first is **conscience**, by which God registers His approval or disapproval within us. Nee held that conscience is not merely a socially formed sense of right and wrong but the place where the Spirit speaks most directly and most unavoidably.

Which shew the work of the law written in their hearts, their conscience also bearing witness.

ROMANS 2:15

He taught believers to keep the conscience extremely tender, and warned that a conscience repeatedly overruled becomes progressively silent — *having their conscience seared with a hot iron* (1 Timothy 4:2). A believer who has learned to argue with his conscience has disabled his most reliable instrument.

The second is **intuition**, by which he meant direct spiritual knowing that does not arrive by reasoning. This is the inward sense that something is right or wrong before one can say why. Nee grounded it in the Spirit's witness:

The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God.

ROMANS 8:16

Assurance of salvation, he pointed out, is precisely of this kind. No believer reasons his way to it, and no argument can finally remove it.

The third is **communion**, or fellowship — the capacity by which we actually worship, as distinct from thinking about God or feeling moved by Him.

God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth.

JOHN 4:24

The practical value of this threefold description is diagnostic. A believer can ask which faculty is engaged. Am I troubled in conscience, which requires confession or restitution? Do I have an intuitive check, which requires waiting? Or am I simply out of communion, which requires returning?

Held as descriptions of experience rather than as a map of the soul's architecture, they remain useful. Held as a system to be applied by introspection, they become the very soulishness Nee was warning against.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Ask honestly after your next moving worship service: was that God, or was that music? The question is not cynical. It is discernment.

2. Notice this week when you are drawing on mental cleverness or emotional energy in ministry rather than on God. Name one instance.
3. Let Scripture do the dividing. When you want to examine yourself, read the Word rather than turning inward.
4. Resist making a system of this. If you find yourself analysing your inner parts more than you are looking at Christ, stop.
5. Hold the doctrine loosely and the pastoral warning tightly. Be gracious with believers who read these texts differently.

A PRAYER

Father, I do not fully understand myself, and I have often mistaken my own feelings for Your presence and my own reasoning for Your voice.

Let Your Word do its work in me. Divide what is merely mine from what is truly Yours. I would rather be cut than deceived.

Keep me from turning this into a study of myself. Turn my eyes outward and upward, to Christ, in whom alone I am safe. Amen.

The Breaking of the Outer Man

Except a corn of wheat fall into the ground and die, it abideth alone: but if it die, it bringeth forth much fruit.

JOHN 12:24

If there is one book of Watchman Nee's that his own generation of workers found most searching, it is the short volume published in English as *The Release of the Spirit*. Its argument can be stated in a sentence, and the sentence is uncomfortable.

The believer's greatest hindrance is not his weakness. It is his unbroken strength.

The alabaster box

Nee took his controlling image from Bethany.

And being in Bethany ...there came a woman having an alabaster box of ointment of spikenard very precious; and she brake the box, and poured it on his head.

MARK 14:3

The value was in the ointment, not the alabaster. But so long as the box remained whole, the fragrance stayed inside, and the house smelled of nothing at all. Only when the alabaster was broken did the perfume fill the room.

So, Nee argued, with the believer. Christ dwells within by His Spirit — that is the treasure. But around that treasure is the outer man: our natural capability, our personality, our cleverness, our forcefulness, our charm, our opinions, our self-love. And the outer man does not automatically transmit the inner life. Frequently it imprisons it.

But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:7

The next verses describe the vessel being knocked about — troubled, perplexed, persecuted, cast down — and Paul draws the conclusion himself: *always bearing about in the body the dying of the Lord Jesus, that the life also of Jesus might be made manifest in our body* (2 Corinthians 4:10). The dying is the condition of the manifesting.

Gifted, and useless

Nee made an observation about ministry which is easier to accept in principle than in practice.

Two men may preach the same sermon from the same text with the same accuracy, and one leaves the hearers informed while the other leaves them undone. The difference is not the content, the intelligence, the eloquence, or even the sincerity. It is whether the man himself has been broken.

An unbroken servant of God can be enormously impressive and spiritually sterile. His natural gifts are so strong that people meet the gift and never reach the Christ behind it. He gets in the way without ever intending to, and he is usually the last person to know.

This is why, in Nee's view, God's central work in a servant is not the augmenting of his abilities but the reduction of his self-confidence.

How the breaking comes

And how does God do it? Not, Nee said, by our arrangement.

We cannot break ourselves. Every attempt at self-imposed brokenness produces a new and subtler form of self-admiration — the man is now proud of his humility. God alone knows where the shell is thickest, and God alone can strike accurately.

The instruments He uses are ordinary. A ministry that does not open as we expected. A rebuke we did not deserve, or one we did. A colleague who is promoted over us. Illness. Failure. The long, grinding disappointment of a work that never becomes what we envisioned. Nee's counsel was to recognise the hand of God in these and to stop resisting.

The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit: a broken and a contrite heart, O God, thou wilt not despise.

PSALM 51:17

He drew attention to Jacob at Peniel — the man who wrestled and prevailed and went away limping for life. The limp was the blessing. The strong man had at last met Someone stronger, and the name he was given afterwards belonged to the crippled man, not the wrestler.

Broken, not destroyed

An important balance. Breaking is not the annihilation of personality. The alabaster box is broken; the ointment is not. Peter after Pentecost is still recognisably Peter — bold, quick, impetuous by temperament — but the boldness now serves Christ instead of Peter.

God does not want colourless servants. He wants servants whose distinctiveness has been brought under the cross so that it conveys Christ rather than obstructing Him.

There is no shortcut here, and Nee offered none. He simply asked his hearers to stop defending the shell. Most of us spend our lives protecting exactly what God is trying to break — our reputation, our right to

be understood, our record of being right. To lay those down voluntarily is not to be broken; only God does that. But it is to cease fighting Him while He does it.

Receiving the discipline

Since we cannot break ourselves, the question becomes how to respond when God does it. Nee taught that everything depends on the attitude taken to the instrument.

My son, despise not thou the chastening of the Lord, nor faint when thou art rebuked of him.

HEBREWS 12:5

Two failures are named there, and Nee treated them as the two ditches on either side of the road.

To **despise** the chastening is to refuse its meaning — to treat the difficulty as an accident, a mere administrative problem, an injustice to be resisted or a personality clash to be managed. The man does everything about his circumstances and nothing about himself. He may even succeed in escaping the situation, in which case God will generally arrange another.

To **faint** is the opposite error: to be crushed, to conclude that God is against us, to give up. Nee had pastoral sympathy here, because the process is genuinely painful and often prolonged. But he insisted the two errors have the same root — both misread the hand behind the event.

Now no chastening for the present seemeth to be joyous, but grievous: nevertheless afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness unto them which are exercised thereby.

HEBREWS 12:11

He drew attention to the last clause. The fruit is not automatic; it belongs to those *exercised thereby*. Two men may pass through identical trouble; one emerges softened and the other hardened, and the difference lies in how each received it.

Nee added two observations that have comforted many.

First, God chooses the instrument, and He chooses accurately. The thing that breaks us is rarely the thing we would have picked, and is almost always the thing we most wished to avoid. That precision is not cruelty. It is evidence of attention.

Second, God does not break more than is necessary, and He does not break carelessly. The purpose is release, not ruin. He is after the fragrance, not the destruction of the vessel.

A bruised reed shall he not break, and the smoking flax shall he not quench.

ISAIAH 42:3

The One who does this work is the same One who would not break what was already bruised. That is worth remembering at two o'clock in the morning.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Identify your strongest natural gift. Ask God whether it has come under the cross or whether people meet it before they meet Christ.
2. Recall the most painful thing God has permitted in the last five years. Ask whether you have been resisting it as an obstacle rather than receiving it as a hand upon the shell.
3. The next time you are misunderstood, do not explain yourself. Let it stand for one day and watch what rises in you.
4. Stop protecting your reputation in one specific relationship this week.
5. Ask a trusted friend where your personality gets in the way of your ministry. Do not defend the answer.

A PRAYER

Lord, I have asked You many times to increase my usefulness, and I do not think I have ever asked You to break me.

I have guarded my reputation. I have insisted on being understood. I have defended the very shell that keeps Your fragrance shut inside me.

I cannot break myself, and if I tried I would only become proud of it. So I ask instead: do it Yourself, in Your own way, at Your own hour, and hold me steady when it hurts. Let there be less of me, so there may be more of You. Amen.

The Latent Power of the Soul

Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God: because many false prophets are gone out into the world.

1 JOHN 4:1

We come now to the most contested thing Watchman Nee ever taught, and it would be dishonest to present his ministry without it.

In 1933 he published a short book whose English title is *The Latent Power of the Soul*. It is brief, strange, and has caused more argument than anything else he wrote.

The argument

Nee began from the dominion given to Adam.

And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness: and let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over the cattle, and over all the earth.

GENESIS 1:26

Adam, he reasoned, possessed capacities far beyond anything we now know — faculties of knowledge and mastery suited to the government of a whole creation. When he fell, God did not annihilate these powers. Instead they were shut up, buried, rendered dormant. The flesh became, in Nee's phrase, a prison to the soul's abilities.

The powers remain, latent, in every descendant of Adam. And here is the point of the book: Satan works to release them. Occult phenomena — telepathy, second sight, hypnotic influence, the transmission of thought, powers displayed in heathen religion — are, on this reading, not necessarily the direct action of demons in every case, but the awakening of buried human soul-power under satanic direction.

Nee's warning was twofold. First, that a believer might unwittingly develop and use this soul-force in Christian work, mistaking it for the power of the Holy Spirit. Second, that in the last days such power would be released on a great scale to support the deception of Antichrist.

Even him, whose coming is after the working of Satan with all power and signs and lying wonders.

2 THESSALONIANS 2:9

His conclusion was that the believer's soul-power must be kept under the cross — not developed, not cultivated, not released, but held in death, so that only the Holy Spirit operates through him.

What is genuinely valuable here

Strip away the speculative framework and a real pastoral concern remains, and it is one the New Testament shares.

There is such a thing as spiritual power that is not from God. Scripture says so plainly. Pharaoh's magicians duplicated some of Moses' signs. Simon of Samaria had bewitched a city. The girl at Philippi brought her masters much gain by soothsaying, and what she said about Paul was perfectly accurate. The Lord Himself warned that many would come to Him having prophesied, cast out devils and done many wonderful works in His name, and would hear *I never knew you* (Matthew 7:22–23).

Nee's insistence that results do not validate a ministry is therefore thoroughly biblical, and badly needed in every generation. Crowds, healings, manifestations, influence over people, the ability to move an audience — none of these is self-authenticating. A man may be powerful and not be sent.

For such are false apostles, deceitful workers, transforming themselves into the apostles of Christ. And no marvel; for Satan himself is transformed into an angel of light.

2 CORINTHIANS 11:13–14

Equally sound is his warning about the preacher who has learned to work upon a congregation — who knows how to build the emotional pressure, when to drop the voice, how to produce a response. That is a real danger, and it is not less dangerous for being unconscious.

Where it must be questioned

Now the other side, and it must be said plainly, because a book that presented this teaching without qualification would be doing the reader harm.

The theory of latent Adamic soul-power is not taught in Scripture. It is a construction, built by inference upon Genesis 1:26 and a handful of texts that do not naturally bear it, and it owes a good deal to nineteenth-century writers who were preoccupied with the occult — G. H. Pember and Jessie Penn-Lewis among them — whose works Nee absorbed through Margaret Barber's library. The Bible nowhere describes Adam as possessing psychic faculties, nowhere says those faculties were made dormant, and nowhere identifies occult phenomena as their release.

The practical dangers of the theory are considerable, and church history has demonstrated them. It supplies a mechanism for attributing to human soul-power any spiritual phenomenon one dislikes, which makes it an instrument for dismissing the genuine work of God without examining it. It can foster a chronic suspicion of one's own facul-

ties, so that a believer becomes afraid of his mind, his emotions and his imagination — all of which God made and intends to sanctify, not suppress. And it can breed a fearful, inward-looking spirituality that is preoccupied with hidden dangers rather than occupied with Christ.

The apostolic method of testing is not a theory of soul-power. It is simpler and more reliable:

Hereby know ye the Spirit of God: Every spirit that confesseth that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is of God.

1 JOHN 4:2

Ye shall know them by their fruits.

MATTHEW 7:16

Doctrine about Christ, and fruit in the life. Those are the tests Scripture gives, and they are sufficient.

How then should this chapter be used? Take the warning and leave the theory. Refuse to be impressed by power as such. Test everything by the Word and by fruit. Be honest about the manipulative techniques available to anyone who speaks in public. But do not adopt a speculative anthropology that Scripture does not teach, and do not let fear of your own soul make you a timid, suspicious Christian. Nee himself would have said — has said, repeatedly, elsewhere — that the safest believer is the one whose attention is on the Lord.

What Scripture does say

Having questioned the theory, it would be a mistake to leave the reader with the impression that the New Testament is unconcerned about spiritual danger. It is very concerned, and it speaks about it clearly. The point is that what it actually says is both more sober and more encouraging than the framework built upon it.

Scripture affirms that the conflict is real and that its adversaries are not merely human.

For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places.

EPHESIANS 6:12

It affirms that deception is the enemy's principal method, and that believers should be alert to it — *lest Satan should get an advantage of us: for we are not ignorant of his devices* (2 Corinthians 2:11).

And it affirms, with equal clarity, that the outcome is not in question, that the believer is not helpless, and that the indwelling Christ is greater than anything ranged against him.

Ye are of God, little children, and have overcome them: because greater is he that is in you, than he that is in the world.

What Scripture does not do is invite us into detailed speculation about mechanisms. It gives no anatomy of how occult power operates. It supplies no taxonomy of spiritual forces for our study. The information it withholds is information we do not need, and the New Testament's reticence on the subject is itself instructive.

The apostolic pattern is therefore: be aware, be armed, be unimpressed by displays of power, and be occupied with Christ. Believers who follow that pattern are safe. Believers who become specialists in the workings of darkness frequently are not — they grow fearful, suspicious of other Christians, and strangely fascinated by the very thing they claim to oppose.

Finally, brethren, whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure ...think on these things.

PHILIPPIANS 4:8

That is Paul's instruction about what to fill the mind with, given in a letter written from prison by a man who knew perfectly well that the powers of darkness were real.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Adopt the two apostolic tests as your settled practice: what does this teach about Christ, and what fruit does it produce over time?
2. Examine your own public ministry, if you have one, for techniques that work on people rather than serve them. Name one and abandon it.
3. Refuse to be moved by results alone — whether other people's or your own.
4. Where you have been suspicious of a genuine work of God because it was unfamiliar, repent of it.
5. Do not become a hunter of counterfeits. Give more attention to knowing Christ than to identifying the false.

A PRAYER

Lord, I want to be discerning without becoming suspicious, and open without becoming gullible. I cannot manage either balance on my own.

Keep me from every power that is not Yours, including the power of my own personality over other people. Where I have learned to manipulate, forgive me and unteach me.

And keep me from fear. You did not give me a spirit of fear. Fix my attention on Christ, and let me test all things by Your Word. Amen.

Authority and Submission

*Let every soul be subject unto the higher powers. For there is no power
but of God: the powers that be are ordained of God.*

ROMANS 13:1

In the summers of 1948 and 1949, on Kuling Mountain near Foo-chow, Watchman Nee gathered the workers for what proved to be the last training of his life. The messages he gave there were afterwards published as *Spiritual Authority*, and they are among the most penetrating — and the most dangerous — things he ever said.

Authority is the first principle of the universe

Nee's starting point was that the deepest issue in the universe is not sin but authority. Sin is a symptom. Rebellion is the disease.

He traced it to the fall of Lucifer, in whom the first act of rebellion was a declaration of independence:

I will ascend into heaven, I will exalt my throne above the stars of God ...I will be like the most High.

ISAIAH 14:13–14

Five times *I will*. Nothing immoral is proposed. What is proposed is self-government. And that, Nee argued, is the essence of all sin: not chiefly the doing of wrong things, but the refusal to be under.

The same pattern appears in Eden. The serpent's offer was autonomy — *ye shall be as gods* (Genesis 3:5) — and the fruit was merely the mechanism.

Against this stands the obedience of the Son.

And being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross.

PHILIPPIANS 2:8

Christ, who was equal with God, took the position of submission and never once left it. That, in Nee's teaching, is the restoration of the moral order of the universe.

Delegated authority

From this he drew his second point: God exercises His authority through delegates. Parents in the home. Elders in the church. Masters over servants. Rulers in the state. Husbands in the marriage. These are not merely convenient social arrangements; they are, in his view,

appointments through which God governs, and how a man treats them reveals how he regards God.

He took his examples chiefly from the Old Testament. Korah, Dathan and Abiram, who challenged Moses and were swallowed by the earth. Miriam, struck with leprosy for speaking against her brother. Ham, cursed through his son for exposing his father's shame while his two brothers walked backwards with a garment. Above all David, who twice had Saul in his hand and would not touch him, though Saul was murderous, disobedient and already rejected by God — *for who can stretch forth his hand against the Lord's anointed, and be guiltless?* (1 Samuel 26:9).

David's restraint is the model. The authority was corrupt; the office was still God's. And David left the removal of Saul to God, which God duly accomplished without David's help.

Submission and obedience are not the same

Here Nee made a distinction that saves the whole teaching from becoming monstrous, and it deserves emphasis.

Obedience is a matter of conduct; submission is a matter of attitude. Obedience is conditional — there are commands a believer must not obey. Submission is unconditional in spirit, in the sense that we never adopt the posture of a rebel.

When the Sanhedrin forbade the apostles to preach, Peter and John did not obey.

We ought to obey God rather than men.

ACTS 5:29

But they did not revile the council, organise against it, or set themselves up as an alternative authority. They declined to obey, and they accepted the beating. That is submission without obedience, and Nee held it up as the pattern: where a delegated authority commands what God forbids, the believer must refuse — and must refuse in a spirit that is not rebellious, accepting whatever consequences follow.

A necessary and serious warning

This teaching has been abused, and any honest presentation of it must say so clearly.

In some circles influenced by these messages — and in many others that never heard of Watchman Nee — the doctrine of delegated authority has been used to shield leaders from accountability, to silence legitimate questions, to characterise every criticism as rebellion, and to keep the abused in submission to their abusers. The results have been grievous: congregations manipulated, finances unexamined, sin

covered, and the vulnerable told that God required their silence.

Nothing in Scripture supports this, and several things in Scripture forbid it. Paul withstood Peter to the face and said so publicly (Galatians 2:11). The Bereans were commended for checking an apostle's preaching against the Scriptures (Acts 17:11). Elders are to be examined before appointment and rebuked before all if they sin (1 Timothy 5:19–20). The shepherds of God's flock are explicitly forbidden to lord it over those in their charge (1 Peter 5:3). And the entire prophetic literature of the Old Testament consists of men sent by God to confront kings and priests.

Nee himself submitted to a discipline he believed unjust, and did so for years without defending himself, which lends his teaching a moral weight it would otherwise lack. But the safeguard must be stated as plainly as the principle: *authority is never a licence, and submission is never a substitute for truth*. A leader who uses this doctrine to protect himself has, by that very act, stepped outside the authority he claims.

Where it is learned

Nee's teaching on authority was given to full-time workers, but he was insistent that the training ground is not the ministry. It is the ordinary household.

The New Testament bears this out. Every extended passage on authority in the epistles is domestic and occupational before it is ecclesiastical: wives and husbands, children and parents, servants and masters.

Servants, be obedient to them that are your masters according to the flesh, with fear and trembling, in singleness of your heart, as unto Christ; not with eyeservice, as menpleasers; but as the servants of Christ, doing the will of God from the heart.

EPHESIANS 6:5–6

Nee drew attention to the phrase *not with eyeservice*. The test of submission is what a man does when the authority is not watching. Work performed well only under observation is not obedience; it is management of appearances.

He also noticed the extraordinary clause that follows in Colossians: *and whatsoever ye do, do it heartily, as to the Lord, and not unto men* (Colossians 3:23). The believer is never, finally, serving his employer. He is serving Christ through an arrangement Christ has permitted. This transforms ordinary work — and it also protects the worker, since a man whose real Master is in heaven cannot be owned by anyone on earth.

Peter takes the same principle into genuinely difficult territory:

Servants, be subject to your masters with all fear; not only to the good and gentle, but also to the froward.

1 PETER 2:18

The froward — the crooked, the unreasonable. And Peter's ground for this is not that the master deserves it, but that Christ endured injustice without retaliating and left us an example.

Two things must be said to hold this rightly.

The first is that Peter is describing an attitude within suffering, not a prohibition on seeking redress. Paul used his Roman citizenship and appealed to Caesar. A believer may lawfully leave a bad employer, report a crime, or seek protection.

The second follows from the previous section of this chapter: nothing here authorises anyone to remain in danger. Where there is abuse, the biblical response is not silent endurance but rescue, and any teacher who uses these verses to keep a person in harm's way has inverted their meaning entirely.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Examine your heart for the rebellion beneath your sins — the preference for self-government — rather than only the sins themselves.
2. Identify one authority in your life you routinely criticise in your heart. Whatever its failings, deal with your own attitude first.
3. Where you must disobey, do it openly, respectfully, and accept the consequences without agitating.
4. If you hold authority, ask whether you have ever used the language of submission to avoid being questioned. Repent of it specifically.
5. Read 1 Peter 5:1–4 alongside this chapter and let it govern how you lead.

A PRAYER

Father, You are God and I am not. I confess how much of my sin is simply the wish to govern myself.

Teach me the mind of Christ, who was equal with You and yet took the lowest place, obedient unto death.

Where I must stand against what is wrong, give me courage without bitterness and firmness without pride. And where I hold any authority over others, guard me from ever using Your name to protect myself. Amen.

The Body of Christ

For as the body is one, and hath many members, and all the members of that one body, being many, are one body: so also is Christ.

1 CORINTHIANS 12:12

Nee's teaching on the church begins not with organisation, government or meetings, but with a fact he regarded as the great neglected revelation of the New Testament: the church is a Body, and a body is a living thing.

Not an illustration but a reality

He pressed hard on the last four words of the verse above. Paul builds his comparison — as the body is one and has many members — and then, where we expect him to conclude *so also is the church*, he writes *so also is Christ*.

The Body is not a picture of the church. It is what the church is, and its life is Christ's own.

And hath put all things under his feet, and gave him to be the head over all things to the church, which is his body, the fulness of him that filleth all in all.

EPHESIANS 1:22–23

From this Nee drew a conclusion that governed all his thinking about church matters: you cannot organise a body. You may organise a machine, a company, an army. A body is not assembled; it grows, and it grows from a life already present within it. Every attempt to produce church life by structure alone is, on this view, an attempt to manufacture what only God can generate.

From whom the whole body fitly joined together and compacted by that which every joint supplieth, according to the effectual working in the measure of every part, maketh increase of the body unto the edifying of itself in love.

EPHESIANS 4:16

The end of independence

The practical force of the Body doctrine, in Nee's hands, was the demolition of the independent Christian.

And the eye cannot say unto the hand, I have no need of thee: nor again the head to the feet, I have no need of you.

1 CORINTHIANS 12:21

He observed that no member of a body functions for itself, and no member functions alone. A hand severed from the body retains its

shape for a while and loses its usefulness immediately. Nee applied this to the private, self-sufficient Christianity that was already common in his day and is far commoner in ours — the believer who reads, prays, listens to preaching and answers to no one.

Such a person, he argued, cannot grow properly, because growth is a Body function. He cannot see properly, because sight in spiritual things is given to the Body and mediated through it. And he cannot serve properly, because gifts are given not to individuals for their own use but to individuals for the Body's sake.

But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to every man to profit withal.

1 CORINTHIANS 12:7

Learning to receive

There is an aspect of this that Nee emphasised more than most teachers, and it is worth dwelling on: the necessity of receiving from other members.

Pride, he said, shows itself in ministry less by an unwillingness to give than by an unwillingness to receive. We are glad to help; we resent needing help. But if the Body is real, then God has deliberately distributed what I need into people I did not choose, may not like, and cannot control. To refuse them is to refuse Him.

He connected this to the practice of fellowship in decision-making. A believer who has an impression about the Lord's will does well, he taught, to bring it to the fellowship of mature brethren rather than acting alone — not because the brethren are infallible, but because the Body has a sense that no single member possesses.

One Body, and only one

Finally, Nee insisted that the Body's unity is not an aspiration but a fact.

There is one body, and one Spirit, even as ye are called in one hope of your calling.

EPHESIANS 4:4

We are not asked to create unity. We are asked to keep it: *endeavouring to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace* (Ephesians 4:3). Division, on this view, is not the breaking of the Body — which cannot be broken — but the denial in practice of something that remains true in fact.

Whatever a reader concludes about Nee's more particular views on church order, which we come to next, this much is beyond argument and profoundly practical: you cannot be a Christian by yourself. The New Testament does not envisage it, and God has arranged the supply of grace so that a believer who withdraws from the Body starves in the middle of plenty.

Gifts, ministries, and the measure of Christ

If the Body is real, what are the gifts for? Nee found the answer in a passage he treated as the charter of Christian ministry.

And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers; for the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ.

EPHESIANS 4:11–12

He laid stress on the purpose clause. The gifted men are given *for the perfecting of the saints* — the word suggests the setting of a bone, the mending of nets, the fitting of something for its function. Their business is not to do the work of the ministry on everyone else's behalf. It is to equip the saints so that the saints do it.

This underlay his hostility to a professional clergy, discussed further in the next chapter. Where one man performs and the rest observe, the arrangement is not merely inefficient; it prevents the Body from functioning and stunts every member in it.

He also emphasised the goal towards which all this equipping runs:

Till we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ.

EPHESIANS 4:13

Till we all come. The destination is corporate. Nee took this to mean that no individual believer, however advanced, arrives on his own. The measure of the fullness of Christ is not attainable by a person; it is attainable by a Body. Which means that my growth is bound up with yours, and that the maturity of the whole is genuinely delayed by the immaturity of the parts.

There is a sobering implication he did not shrink from. If the Body is real, my private sin is not private. It does not injure me alone.

And whether one member suffer, all the members suffer with it; or one member be honoured, all the members rejoice with it.

1 CORINTHIANS 12:26

And there is an encouraging implication too, which he pressed just as hard. My smallest faithful service is not small, because it is not mine alone either. The obscure member who prays, gives and endures unnoticed is supplying something to the whole that the whole cannot obtain elsewhere.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Name three believers you regularly receive from — not teach, not serve, but receive from. If you cannot name three, that is the finding.

2. Bring your next significant decision to two or three mature believers before you act, and genuinely listen.
3. Identify a member of your congregation you consider unnecessary. Ask God to show you what He has put in them for you.
4. Where you have contributed to division, take one concrete step of repair this month.
5. Ask what your gift is for. If the answer is chiefly your own fulfilment, reconsider.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You are the Head, and I am a member — one among many, and not the most important.

Forgive my independence. I have prized being useful and resisted being needy. I have chosen which believers I would receive from, as though the supply were mine to arrange.

Join me truly to Your Body. Teach me to receive as freely as I give, to keep the unity You have already made, and to seek the profit of the whole rather than the enlargement of myself. Amen.

The Church in the Place

*Unto the church of God which is at Corinth ...with all that in every place
call upon the name of Jesus Christ our Lord.*

1 CORINTHIANS 1:2

In 1938 Nee published the work known in English as *The Normal Christian Church Life*, sometimes titled *Concerning Our Missions*. It is his fullest treatment of church practice, and it is the part of his teaching about which believers most reasonably differ.

The observation

His argument begins with an observation about New Testament vocabulary that is difficult to dispute.

Whenever the Scriptures speak of a church in a geographical sense, the identifier is always a *place* — never a doctrine, a founder, a practice or an emphasis. The church at Jerusalem, at Antioch, at Corinth, at Ephesus, at Philippi. The seven churches of Revelation are named for seven cities. There is no church of Peter, no church of the circumcision party, no church of those who prefer a particular view of the Lord's Table.

Further, Nee noted, the New Testament never speaks of two churches in one city, nor of one church spread over several cities. The unit is the locality, and within that locality every believer belongs.

From this he concluded that division among Christians in the same town has no scriptural warrant whatsoever, and that the very existence of competing societies in one place — however orthodox each may be — is a departure from the apostolic pattern. He noted that when Paul confronted the Corinthians for saying *I am of Paul; and I of Apollos; and I of Cephas*, he did not merely reprove partisanship; he asked *Is Christ divided?* (1 Corinthians 1:12–13).

His practical conclusion was that believers should gather simply as the church in their city, on no other ground than that they are Christians living there, receiving all whom Christ receives.

Wherefore receive ye one another, as Christ also received us to the glory of God.

ROMANS 15:7

What follows from it

Several practical convictions flowed from this, and they shaped the assemblies that grew up under his ministry.

There should be no clergy-laity division, since the Body has many functioning members and no professional class. Elders are local and plural, raised up from among the believers rather than sent in. Apostles — or workers — travel, plant and build up, but do not govern the local churches or belong to them administratively. Meetings should allow for the contribution of the members rather than the performance of one man, on the pattern of *when ye come together, every one of you hath a psalm, hath a doctrine* (1 Corinthians 14:26). And the work should be supported by God's provision rather than by solicitation.

Whatever one makes of the whole system, several of these emphases have proved their worth in the hardest circumstances imaginable. When the state closed the church buildings in China, the assemblies that survived and multiplied were precisely those that had never depended on paid clergy, denominational structures or property.

Where careful believers differ

Honesty requires the other side, and it should not be softened.

Many thoughtful Christians accept Nee's exegetical observation and reject his conclusion. That the New Testament identifies churches by city may reflect the simple fact that in the first century there was only one Christian community in each city, rather than establishing a permanent law of church order. Descriptive history is not always prescriptive command, and Scripture nowhere states the principle in the form of a rule.

There is also a practical difficulty that the principle carries within itself. If the ground of locality is what makes a gathering legitimate, then a group claiming that ground has implicitly denied it to everyone else in the town — and a doctrine devised to end division has become a new and particularly sharp instrument of it. This is not a hypothetical concern. In the movements that followed Nee, disputes over which gathering constituted the true church in a given city produced painful separations, and the history of that is not edifying.

Nee himself, it should be said, was in practice more generous than the system might suggest; he received believers from many backgrounds and had warm fellowship with Christians who did not share his views on church ground.

How should an ordinary believer handle this chapter? Take the burden and hold the method loosely.

The burden is real, and the New Testament shares it: that Christ has one Body, that our divisions grieve Him, that denominational loyalty must never outrank loyalty to Christ, and that we are obliged to receive every believer whom Christ has received. That much is not a matter of

opinion.

That they all may be one; as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us: that the world may believe that thou hast sent me.

JOHN 17:21

Whether the remedy is a particular structure of gathering is another question altogether, and Christians of goodwill have answered it differently for a very long time.

What survived

There is a postscript to this chapter which no honest treatment can omit, because history has supplied a kind of commentary on it.

When Watchman Nee was arrested in 1952, the assemblies he had served numbered some hundreds across China. Within a few years the buildings were closed, the leaders imprisoned or scattered, the literature destroyed, and public Christian worship as it had been known was effectively ended. During the Cultural Revolution the pressure intensified further. Foreign observers largely assumed that Chinese Protestantism had been extinguished.

It had not. When information began to emerge again in the late 1970s, it became clear that the church had not merely survived but multiplied, chiefly in homes, without buildings, without a paid clergy, without denominational structures, and frequently under leaders with no formal training who had been raised up from among the believers themselves.

It would be an overstatement — and Nee would have disliked it — to credit this to any one man or movement. Many streams contributed, and much of the growth occurred among Christians who had never heard of him. But it is a matter of plain fact that the practices he had argued for from Scripture proved remarkably well suited to a church under a hostile state. A congregation with no building cannot have its building confiscated. A church with no salaried clergy cannot have its clergy defunded. A gathering in which every member can contribute does not collapse when one man is arrested.

There is a lesson in this for believers in every place where the church may one day be pressed, which is to say in every place.

And they that were scattered abroad went every where preaching the word.

ACTS 8:4

The persecution in Acts 8 destroyed the Jerusalem church as a single visible congregation and thereby spread the gospel across the region. What looked like the end of the work was its distribution.

Nee did not live to see any of this. He died in confinement in 1972, at the lowest point, with no evidence whatever that the thing he had given

his life to had survived. Whatever one concludes about his particular views on church order, this much is instructive: he built in a way that did not depend on his own presence, and it outlasted him by a very long way.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. List the believers in your town you would not gladly break bread with. Examine each name and ask whether the reason is scriptural or merely tribal.
2. Do something practical this month across a denominational line — pray together, serve together, give to their work.
3. If you serve in a church, ask honestly whether its structure develops members or spectators.
4. Notice whether your loyalty to your congregation is greater than your loyalty to Christ's whole Body. Test it by how you speak of other churches.
5. Guard against the irony in this chapter: do not let a conviction about unity become a new reason for separation.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You prayed that Your people would be one, and we have spent centuries dividing. Forgive us, and forgive me.

Teach me to receive everyone You have received — not grudgingly, not with conditions of my own devising, but as You have received me.

Where I have prized my own tradition above Your Body, correct me. Where others differ from me and love You, give me a large heart. Make me a builder and not a divider. Amen.

The Ministry of Prayer

Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven.

MATTHEW 6:10

Nee returned to prayer throughout his ministry, and gathered his teaching on it in several places, notably *Let Us Pray* and the messages published as *The Prayer Ministry of the Church*. His treatment is distinctive because of the question he begins with.

Most teaching on prayer asks how the believer may get what he needs from God. Nee asked something else: why does God need the believer to pray at all?

God has bound Himself to ask

His answer rests on the doctrine of authority in the earth. God gave dominion over this world to man (Genesis 1:26; Psalm 115:16). Man fell, and that dominion passed in practice to the usurper. In redemption, God works to recover the earth — and He does it, characteristically, not by sovereign fiat alone but through a redeemed humanity that wills what He wills.

Hence, Nee argued, God has voluntarily limited Himself. He will do a great many things only when His people ask.

Ye have not, because ye ask not.

JAMES 4:2

And he saw that there was no man, and wondered that there was no intercessor.

ISAIAH 59:16

He put it in a figure that has been much repeated: God's will is like a train, and prayer is the track. The train has all the power; it goes nowhere without the rails. Prayer supplies no power at all — and without it the power does not arrive.

This transforms what prayer is for. It is not chiefly a means of obtaining things. It is the agreement of the church with the will of God, by which His will is given a way into the earth.

Again I say unto you, That if two of you shall agree on earth as touching any thing that they shall ask, it shall be done for them of my Father which is in heaven.

MATTHEW 18:19

Praying the will of God

It follows that the first labour of prayer is not speaking but discovering.

Nee taught believers to seek God's mind before making requests, and he was unsparing about how much praying is merely the presentation of our own preferences with a religious ending attached. The Lord's own pattern begins *Thy kingdom come, Thy will be done* — and only afterwards asks for bread.

And this is the confidence that we have in him, that, if we ask any thing according to his will, he heareth us.

1 JOHN 5:14

This is also, he noted, why the Spirit's help is indispensable. We do not know what we should pray for, and the Spirit Himself makes intercession within us (Romans 8:26). Real prayer, on this understanding, originates in heaven, is carried by the Spirit into the heart of a believer, is prayed back to God, and is answered. The believer is the channel, not the source.

Authority in prayer

Nee distinguished several kinds of praying, and reserved particular emphasis for the prayer of authority — the prayer which, rather than pleading with God, speaks to the situation on the basis of Christ's victory.

He pointed to the Lord asleep in the boat. The disciples begged Him to save them; He got up and addressed the wind. He pointed to Moses at the Red Sea, told to stop crying out and to lift up his rod. And he pointed to the promise of the keys:

And I will give unto thee the keys of the kingdom of heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt bind on earth shall be bound in heaven: and whatsoever thou shalt loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven.

MATTHEW 16:19

The church, seated with Christ, has been given the authority to declare on earth what heaven has already determined. But Nee guarded this immediately, and the guard is essential: such prayer is only valid within the will of God, and only from a position of submission. A believer who has not learned obedience has no authority to exercise, and attempting it is presumption.

Persistence, and the discipline of it

Finally, he taught persistence without anxiety. The widow before the unjust judge, the friend at midnight, Elijah sending his servant seven times to look at an empty sky — these are given us not because God is reluctant but because prayer is warfare and warfare takes time.

Pray without ceasing.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:17

And practically, Nee urged the keeping of records — specific requests, dates, answers. Vague praying, he observed, produces vague faith, and a believer who never asks for anything definite will never know whether God has answered.

Praise before the answer

There is one further form of praying which Nee treated as belonging to the highest order, and it is the one most of us reach for last.

And when he had consulted with the people, he appointed singers unto the Lord, and that should praise the beauty of holiness, as they went out before the army, and to say, Praise the Lord; for his mercy endureth for ever.

2 CHRONICLES 20:21

Jehoshaphat's position was hopeless by any military reckoning, and his own prayer had admitted it — *neither know we what to do: but our eyes are upon thee* (2 Chronicles 20:12). What he did next was to put the choir in front of the soldiers. The praise went out before the battle, not after the victory.

Nee's point was not that praise is a technique for obtaining results. He was firm about that; the moment praise is offered in order to make something happen it has become a transaction and ceased to be worship. The point is what praise declares. To thank God before the answer arrives is to state, in the most practical way available, that the matter is already settled with Him.

He pointed also to a Philippian prison at midnight, where two men with bleeding backs and their feet in the stocks sang hymns loudly enough that the other prisoners listened (Acts 16:25). The earthquake came afterwards. The singing was not caused by the deliverance; it preceded it, and it happened in circumstances that offered no encouragement whatever.

By him therefore let us offer the sacrifice of praise to God continually, that is, the fruit of our lips giving thanks to his name.

HEBREWS 13:15

The word *sacrifice* is exact. Praise offered when everything is well costs nothing. Praise offered in the dark costs something, which is precisely what makes it an offering.

Nee's counsel, given to people about to endure a good deal, was to make thanksgiving a discipline rather than a mood: to begin prayer with it, to practise it in trouble specifically, and to refuse to wait for circumstances to justify it.

In every thing give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:18

In every thing, he was careful to note — not for every thing. We are not asked to call evil good. We are asked to find God present in the middle of it, and to say so.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Begin your praying this week by asking what God wants, and spend as long listening as asking.
2. Keep a written list of specific requests with dates. Review it monthly and record the answers.
3. Find one other believer and agree together, in Matthew 18 fashion, on one definite matter.
4. Where you have been begging God to do what He has already accomplished in Christ, change your posture: thank Him, and stand.
5. Examine your prayers for a week. What proportion concerned your comfort, and what proportion concerned His kingdom?

A PRAYER

Father, You have chosen to work through the prayers of Your people, and I have often left the rails unaid.

Forgive me for prayers that were only my own wishes with Your name attached. Teach me to seek Your mind before I open my mouth.

Holy Spirit, pray in me what I do not know how to pray. Give me the persistence that does not let go, and the submission without which authority is only presumption. Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done. Amen.

The Overcomers and the Reward

*To him that overcometh will I grant to sit with me in my throne, even as
I also overcame, and am set down with my Father in his throne.*

REVELATION 3:21

The last strand of Nee's teaching to consider is the one that gave his movement its urgency and its name for suffering. It is the doctrine of the overcomers, set out most fully in the addresses published as *God's Plan and the Overcomers*, and running through much of what he wrote about the kingdom and the church.

God's eternal purpose

Nee began not with the fall but with the purpose that preceded it. God's intention, declared in Genesis 1:26, was a race bearing His image and exercising His dominion. Sin interrupted it; redemption serves it. Salvation, in his framing, is not the end of God's plan but the means by which the original purpose is recovered.

According to the eternal purpose which he purposed in Christ Jesus our Lord.

EPHESIANS 3:11

The consummation is a corporate one: a Body prepared, a Bride made ready, a city descending.

The overcomers

But Nee observed something about the way God has always worked. When the whole fails, God takes a remnant, and through the remnant recovers the whole. Noah in the flood. The seven thousand who had not bowed to Baal. Gideon's three hundred. The returning exiles under Zerubbabel.

He applied this to the church. The Lord's word to the seven churches of Asia is addressed to whole congregations, but the promise is invariably narrowed: *to him that overcometh*. Not to the church as a whole — to those within it who overcome.

He that overcometh shall inherit all things; and I will be his God, and he shall be my son.

REVELATION 21:7

The overcomers, in Nee's teaching, are not a superior class of Christian with a different salvation. They are simply the believers who are actually living the normal Christian life — those in whom the cross has

done its work — and God uses them to secure His purpose for the whole Body.

Salvation and reward

Here Nee made his most controversial eschatological distinction, and it must be set out accurately and then examined.

He held — following Robert Govett, G. H. Pember and D. M. Panton, whose works he had absorbed early — that Scripture distinguishes between salvation, which is by grace through faith and cannot be lost, and reward, which is according to works and can be forfeited. Every believer will be saved. Not every believer will reign.

If any man's work abide which he hath built thereupon, he shall receive a reward. If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire.

1 CORINTHIANS 3:14–15

For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ; that every one may receive the things done in his body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:10

From this he taught that some believers will enter the coming kingdom's reign and others will not, that the millennial reign is a reward rather than a universal Christian entitlement, and that a believer may suffer real loss — though never the loss of salvation itself.

Weighing it

The distinction between salvation and reward is plainly biblical. The passages above teach it, and so do the parables of the talents and the pounds. Believers who ignore it tend towards a complacency the New Testament never permits.

But the further elaboration — a partial rapture, exclusion of some believers from the millennial kingdom, a period of remedial discipline for the unfaithful — rests on a chain of inferences rather than on plain statements, and the majority of evangelical interpreters have not been persuaded. These are matters on which sincere believers have disagreed for a long time, and the wise reader will hold them lightly.

What should not be held lightly is the moral point beneath them, which is unmistakably apostolic: how a Christian lives now will matter then.

But I keep under my body, and bring it into subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway.

1 CORINTHIANS 9:27

There is something fitting in ending here, because this doctrine was not theoretical for the man who taught it.

Watchman Nee spoke about the overcomers to workers who would shortly be scattered, imprisoned and in some cases killed. He himself spent the last twenty years of his life in confinement, refusing his freedom on the terms offered. He was denounced by former colleagues, buried his wife without being permitted to attend, and died on a labour farm in Anhwei with a piece of paper under his pillow affirming that Christ is the Son of God who died for sinners and rose again, and that he still believed it.

He had preached that the crown goes to those who overcome. He was required to prove whether he meant it.

Be thou faithful unto death, and I will give thee a crown of life.

REVELATION 2:10

The Bride made ready

Nee's overcomer teaching has an end in view, and it is not individual. He set it out most fully in *The Glorious Church*, tracing a single thread from the first pages of Scripture to the last.

He began at Eden, with a detail he considered deliberate. Eve was not formed separately from the dust as Adam had been; she was taken out of the man, from his opened side, while a deep sleep was upon him.

And the Lord God caused a deep sleep to fall upon Adam, and he slept: and he took one of his ribs ...and the rib, which the Lord God had taken from man, made he a woman.

GENESIS 2:21–22

In this Nee saw a foreshadowing of the last Adam, from whose opened side on the cross came the church — a bride of the same nature as the Bridegroom, drawn out of His death.

Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it; that he might sanctify and cleanse it ...that he might present it to himself a glorious church, not having spot, or wrinkle, or any such thing.

EPHESIANS 5:25–27

The consummation, then, is a wedding.

Let us be glad and rejoice, and give honour to him: for the marriage of the Lamb is come, and his wife hath made herself ready.

REVELATION 19:7

Two words in that verse carried Nee's whole burden. *Made herself ready* — there is something the Bride does, and it is not automatic. And *his wife*, singular — the readiness is corporate. There is no such thing as an individual bride.

This is where the overcomer teaching finds its proper proportion, and it guards against the misuse the doctrine invites. The overcomers are not a spiritual elite being rewarded for outperforming their

brethren. They are those in whom God has been able to do His work, and the purpose of that work is not their private distinction but the readiness of the whole. They are the firstfruits, not the harvest; the vanguard, not the destination.

Understood that way, the doctrine produces exactly the opposite of spiritual competition. A man who grasps it does not ask how he may be counted among the overcomers. He asks what it will cost him to be of use to the Body, and he stops keeping score — which is, in Nee's terms, a fair sign that the cross has begun its work.

FOR REFLECTION AND ACTION

1. Live this week with the judgment seat of Christ genuinely in view. Let it affect one specific decision.
2. Distinguish clearly in your own mind between what is settled — your salvation — and what is not yet settled: your faithfulness.
3. Identify one area where you are building with wood, hay and stubble — activity that will not survive the fire. Stop, or rebuild it.
4. Hold the disputed details lightly and the moral urgency tightly. Do not divide from anyone over the finer points of the kingdom.
5. Ask what you would refuse to surrender if it cost you your liberty. Then ask whether you are living now as though that were true.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, You are coming, and I will stand before You, and the fire will test what I have built.

I thank You that my salvation is not in question — it rests wholly on Your finished work. But my faithfulness is very much in question, and I ask You to deal with me now rather than to leave it until then.

Make me an overcomer, not for the honour of it, but because You are worthy of a people who did not love their lives unto the death. Whatever it costs, keep me faithful to the end. Amen.

Conclusion

He must increase, but I must decrease.

JOHN 3:30

We have covered a great deal of ground in eighteen short chapters, and it would be easy to close this book with the impression that Watchman Nee taught many things. In truth he taught one thing, from many angles, for thirty years.

The one thing is this: *Christ has done everything, and the believer's whole business is to get out of the way.*

Everything else is commentary. The distinction between the blood and the cross is that truth applied to guilt and to nature. Know, reckon, present is that truth applied to the mechanics of daily deliverance. Sit, walk, stand is that truth applied to position, conduct and conflict. The breaking of the outer man is that truth applied to the servant. The Body is that truth applied to the church. And the overcomers are simply those in whom it has been allowed to work.

What to do with it

If you have read this far, you are now in a position of some danger. Nee himself would have said so.

The peculiar hazard of teaching about the deeper life is that it can be received as a subject. A man may become an enthusiast for the doctrine of the cross while remaining entirely uncrucified. He may collect the vocabulary — reckoning, brokenness, soul-life, the Body — and deploy it fluently, and be exactly the same man he was before, only harder to help. Nothing in these pages is of the slightest use as information.

But be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving your own selves.

JAMES 1:22

So here is the plainest counsel this book can give. Go back to the one chapter that made you uncomfortable. Not the one you found most interesting — the one you would rather not read again. That is where God is working. Take the application points at the end of it, and do them, one at a time, slowly, over the coming months. Then take the next.

And expect it to be unspectacular. The great danger of a book like this is that it creates an appetite for crisis — for a single overwhelming experience after which everything is different. Such moments do occur;

Nee's ministry contains several. But the ordinary shape of this work is far less dramatic. It is a long succession of small surrenders, most of them unwitnessed, in which a man gradually stops defending himself.

Two things to carry

Carry away, first, a settled confidence. If you take nothing else from these chapters, take this: your acceptance with God does not fluctuate. It was established at Calvary, it rests on the blood of Christ, and your performance this week did not improve it and cannot damage it. Every genuine advance in the Christian life begins from that security, never from anxiety about it.

Carry away, second, a holy discontent with the ordinary. Not with your circumstances — Nee had rather more to be discontented about than most of us and did not complain — but with the gap between what Scripture says is normal and what we have settled for. That discontent, honestly held before God, is one of the surest signs that the Spirit is at work.

Not as though I had already attained, either were already perfect: but I follow after, if that I may apprehend that for which also I am apprehended of Christ Jesus.

PHILIPPIANS 3:12

A last word about the man

We have been honest in these pages about Watchman Nee's limitations. He speculated where Scripture is silent. He systematised what might have been left as testimony. Parts of his teaching have been used, by others and perhaps sometimes by himself, in ways that did harm. His life contains a period of withdrawal he never fully explained and accusations that will not be settled in this world.

None of that has been raised in order to diminish him. It has been raised because he taught, more insistently than almost anyone, that no servant of God is to be looked at. The man who wrote about the alabaster box would have been appalled to become one.

And so the right response to his ministry is not admiration. It is obedience — not to him, but to the Lord he pointed at, whose life he spent thirty years trying to describe and twenty years quietly proving.

Looking unto Jesus the author and finisher of our faith.

HEBREWS 12:2

The watchman's work is to wake the household and then to be forgotten. He would be content with that.

A PRAYER

Lord Jesus, I have read about Your cross, and I have understood some of it, and I am afraid of leaving it there.

Do not let me become a student of the deeper life instead of a partaker of it. Do not let me acquire words for things I have never experienced.

Take the truth I have seen and press it into me until it costs me something. Begin with the chapter I would rather forget. Begin today.

You must increase. I must decrease. Amen.

A Reader's Guide to Watchman Nee

Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.

2 TIMOTHY 2:15

Nee wrote comparatively little with his own pen. Most of what bears his name consists of spoken addresses taken down by hearers and afterwards edited, translated and published — sometimes long after his death, and in more than one competing English version. Readers should therefore hold particular sentences loosely, especially where a point turns on precise wording. What follows is a guide for further reading, arranged for usefulness rather than chronology.

Begin here

The Normal Christian Life. His best-known book and the natural starting place, drawn from addresses given in Europe in 1938 and 1939 and compiled by Angus Kinnear. An exposition of Romans, and the source of the know–reckon–present–obey sequence treated in chapters four to six of this book.

Sit, Walk, Stand. Very short, and arguably his most perfectly constructed work. An exposition of Ephesians in three movements. If you have an hour, spend it here.

The Release of the Spirit (also published as *The Breaking of the Outer Man and the Release of the Spirit*). Brief, searching, and the book most likely to do you good if you are in Christian work.

For deeper study

The Spiritual Man, three volumes, 1928. His earliest major work, written during severe illness, setting out the spirit–soul–body framework discussed in chapter eleven. Thorough and demanding. Nee himself came to think it over-systematised; read it with that caution.

Spiritual Authority. From the Kuling trainings of 1948–49. Powerful, and to be read alongside 1 Peter 5 and the cautions given in chapter fourteen of this book.

The Character of God's Workman and *The Ministry of God's Word.* Also from the Kuling period. Addressed to those who preach; unusually practical about the moral qualifications of a servant.

What Shall This Man Do? On the three ministries typified by Peter, Paul and John — the fisherman, the builder, the mender. Valuable for

understanding differing callings.

Church and corporate life

The Normal Christian Church Life (originally *Concerning Our Missions*, 1938). His treatment of church order, apostles, elders and the ground of locality. The material behind chapter sixteen. Read critically.

Assembling Together. More practical and less controversial: on baptism, the Lord's Table, laying on of hands and the conduct of meetings.

The Glorious Church. On the church as the bride, tracing the theme from Eve through to the New Jerusalem. Some of his most imaginative writing, with the strengths and risks that implies.

Devotional

A Table in the Wilderness. A daily devotional compiled from his ministry. The gentlest introduction to him, and a good gift.

Changed into His Likeness. On Abraham, Isaac and Jacob as pictures of God's dealings with a man. Warm and pastoral.

Love Not the World. A short, sharp treatment of the world system.

The Song of Songs. His devotional exposition, in the tradition of the mystics he read.

Approach with discernment

The Latent Power of the Soul (1933). Discussed at length in chapter thirteen. Not recommended for a new believer, and not to be read without the qualifications set out there.

God's Plan and the Overcomers, and other material on the kingdom and rewards. The salvation–reward distinction is scriptural; the further eschatological structure is disputed. Read alongside standard evangelical treatments of the same passages.

About Watchman Nee

Against the Tide by Angus Kinnear is the standard sympathetic biography, written by the man who edited *The Normal Christian Life*. *Watchman Nee: A Seer of the Divine Revelation* presents the view of the movement that continued through Witness Lee. For a more critical scholarly assessment, consult the entry in the *Biographical Dictionary of Chinese Christianity* and standard histories of twentieth-century Chinese Protestantism. Reading more than one of these is strongly advised; no single account is disinterested.

A closing note on how to read him

Three counsels, offered in the spirit of 1 Thessalonians 5:21.

Read him with the Bible open, and check every claim. He would have insisted on it.

Read him for the burden rather than the system. Where he presses a framework beyond what Scripture states, take the pastoral concern and leave the scaffolding.

And read him slowly. These are not books to be finished. A page a day, prayed over, will do more than a volume a week admired.

Prove all things; hold fast that which is good.

1 THESSALONIANS 5:21